

Introduction

In human life, **thinking carefully**, using reason, and then **choosing correct beliefs** are extremely important. This is because every belief and way of thinking directly affects a person's destiny and actions. In fact, a person's behavior is the outward expression of their inner beliefs. The fundamental difference between good, righteous, and just people and cruel, corrupt, and unjust people lies in their beliefs and ways of thinking.

For this reason, the Qur'an strongly encourages human beings to **reflect, think, and choose wisely**, calling them toward the best beliefs and commitment to them. It also warns that the worst creatures in God's sight are those who do not think or reason at all. Therefore, before anything else, human beings must think carefully about matters that shape their lives and destiny.

Among the most important and destiny-shaping topics are **understanding the human being, God, and the Hereafter**. If a person truly understands themselves, discovers their inner abilities and natural talents, and uses these hidden treasures properly, they can achieve true happiness and success. Thus, the **first duty of a human being** is to know themselves well: to know what they are created from, who created them, and what abilities have been placed within them.

When self-knowledge is done correctly, it leads naturally to knowledge of **God and the Hereafter**. Belief in God and resurrection completely transforms a person's view of life. Consider a person who sees themselves as a creation of a Wise, All-Knowing, and All-Powerful God, who knows that they are constantly connected to their Creator. Such a person understands that their life has purpose, and they see worldly life as an opportunity for growth and spiritual perfection—not merely for temporary pleasure.

This person does not see the teachings of the prophets as restrictions on freedom, but as tools for spiritual development. They do not limit existence to this material world; instead, they believe that this world is a **field for the Hereafter**, and that their efforts and actions will shape their eternal life. They believe that God watches over all their deeds, and that even the smallest action is not hidden from divine justice. Such a person would never oppress others or burn people's hearts with cruelty. Their behavior would naturally reflect kindness, responsibility, and moral growth.

Now consider another person who reduces themselves to the level of animals, believing that life has no purpose beyond pleasure and enjoyment. They see themselves as a

meaningless product of nature, without wisdom or intention behind their creation. They believe life is limited to this world and that it exists only for maximum enjoyment. In this mindset, exploitation, oppression, and injustice toward others are easily justified in the pursuit of personal pleasure. How would such a person behave?

In this way, the importance of **self-knowledge, knowledge of God, and knowledge of the Hereafter** becomes clear. The role and necessity of the subject *Islamic Thought* in universities is justified precisely for this reason.

This book is a modest effort to encourage rational thinking and correct understanding of these three fundamental topics. We hope it fulfills its purpose. At the same time, since no human work is free from flaws, we warmly welcome constructive criticism from scholars and thinkers.

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Part One: Humanity and Faith

Chapter One: Humanity

A) Self-Knowledge

Among humanity's important issues, and perhaps the most important of them, is human self-knowledge. Before humans investigate the surrounding world and its good and bad aspects, they must know themselves, discover the treasures of their innate nature and being, bring them to perfection, and moderate their carnal and lustful desires. In this case, they attain the greatest happiness. But if they are heedless, do not find and cultivate their potentials, and only fulfill their material needs and carnal and animal desires, they fall into loss and decline from the level of humanity to animality.

The invitation to human self-knowledge is among the important recommendations of divine prophets, moral scholars, mystics, and philosophers, and humans themselves also feel its importance. Of course, humans, from various perspectives, are the subject of knowledge and various sciences. Psychology, sociology, history, ethics, medicine, anatomy, biology, biochemistry, etc., each study humans from a particular viewpoint; but what is meant by human knowledge in this discussion is that humans have potentials and powers for understanding themselves, the world, and human perfection. If humans, through contemplation and reflection, recognize the possibilities and potentials that have been created in them for growth and perfection, they can better bring their existential capital to perfection.

The Qur'an and Islamic narrations invite humans to self-knowledge. The Qur'an says:

1. Humans should look at what they were created from;
2. Does humanity not remember that We created them when they were nothing?
3. O you who have believed! Take care of yourselves...

Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says:

"One who attains self-knowledge has reached the greatest happiness and success."

According to historical accounts, on the door of the temple of Delphi in one of the cities of ancient Greece, to discover the mysteries of creation and human complexities, it was written: "Know thyself!" In the history of philosophy, self-knowledge was one of the fundamental theories of Socrates the wise. Immanuel Kant, one of the great philosophers of the Western world, says:

"Humans, before anything else, must engage in precise evaluation and knowledge of their own capability."

Therefore, there is no room for any doubt about the importance of self-knowledge; but to further clarify the preference and necessity of self-knowledge, the following reasons can be mentioned:

1. Prerequisite for Human Perfection

If humans first know themselves, they can better benefit from their existential capital and cultivate it, because the starting point is knowledge of existential capital. They can ask themselves: Is the existential level of humans at the level of other animals, or do they have the power of development and flight? If they have the power of development and flight to the spiritual realm, to what extent can they fly? If humans do not use their power of development and flight and do not benefit from their existential capital, are they not worthy of reproach? Do humans, apart from this material body, have another reality called the soul? If humans have a soul, what are its needs, and how should they be fulfilled, and how should it develop? The answer to these questions is the prerequisite for human perfection.

2. Prerequisite for World Knowledge

Knowledge of the world comes after human interaction with the world outside themselves. After interaction, humans say, "I see," "I hear," and "I know." The fundamental question is: to what extent does the being we call "I" have a share in knowledge? Is all the share for humans, or is the fundamental share for the external world, or are both participants? The prerequisite for answering this question is self-knowledge. Humans must first know their faculties and instruments of knowledge and the scope and boundaries of these faculties, and then attain knowledge of the world. Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says in this regard:

"How can one who does not know themselves know others?"

"One who knows themselves knows others better, and one who is ignorant of themselves is more ignorant of others."

3. Prerequisite for God-Knowledge

Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says:

"Whoever knows themselves knows their Lord."

Self-knowledge, which is the prerequisite for God-knowledge, can be contemplated from various perspectives:

- Since human nature is mixed with knowledge of God, the invitation to self-knowledge is actually an invitation to God-knowledge and connection with God. Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says:

"O God! You have kneaded hearts with Your love and intellects with Your knowledge."

Therefore, self-knowledge is the prerequisite for love and knowledge of God.

- Human existence is a dependent and contingent existence, and such a being cannot be its own creator. Therefore, when humans engage in self-knowledge, they feel their dependence on God. The noble Qur'an says:

"O mankind, you are those in need of God, while God is the Free of need, the Praiseworthy." (Qur'an 35:15)

- If humans contemplate their complex structure, they become aware of a wise and knowledgeable Ordainer who created such a structure. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And on the earth are signs for the certain [in faith], and in yourselves. Then will you not see?" (Qur'an 51:20-21)

4. Solver of Human Problems

Many of humanity's spiritual, psychological, intellectual, and moral problems stem from self-ignorance. If humans knew their true reality, the purpose of creation, their relationship with God, their position in the system of existence, the effect of worldly life on the hereafter, the role of good morals and proper interaction with others, the share of wealth in the quality of life, and the role of calamities and joys in life, many of their problems would be solved, and they would write a happy life for themselves.

Many of the man-made schools such as materialism, liberalism, Nazism, racial discrimination, capitalism, and atheistic existentialism, which today determine the fate of humans, are rooted in lack of human knowledge. If humans knew themselves well, they would no longer be caught in these schools and could, through reasoning and wisdom, attain true peace, which is intimacy with God and following divine commands.

B) The Reality of Humanity

Regarding the reality of humanity, there are two viewpoints: material and divine. Those who consider existence equal to matter or consider humans as a completely material phenomenon consider all the laws governing the reality of humanity to be material. They believe that with material laws, which are based on sense and experience, humans can be known, and essentially all their analyses about humans are materialistic. Based on this analysis, humans, upon death and the disintegration of their body, are annihilated.

Another group, in addition to the material dimension of humans, also believe in their non-material dimension, and for humans, in addition to the material body, they posit a reality called the soul. Divine religions, especially Islam, agree with the second view. The axis of all the teachings of divine religions is the human soul, and if they also pay attention to the human body, it is because of its effect on the soul. This non-material soul cannot be studied through laws arising from sensory and experimental sciences or with sensory instruments. The instrument for knowing it is non-experimental and non-sensory. Based on this analysis, the soul or non-material dimension of humans is not destroyed by death and the disintegration of the body; rather, it undertakes an eternal life in the hereafter.

From the Qur'anic viewpoint, humans, in addition to the material body, benefit from the divine spirit, and essentially, the reality of humanity is their soul. The Qur'an in some verses explicitly states humanity's dual nature:

"Then He proportioned him and breathed into him from His [created] soul." (Qur'an 32:9)

"[So mention] when your Lord said to the angels, 'Indeed, I am going to create a human being from clay. So when I have proportioned him and breathed into him of My [created] soul, then fall down to him in prostration.'" (Qur'an 15:28-29)

"Taswiyah" (proportioning) in this verse means the creation of the body's organs in a balanced manner, free from excess and deficiency. In Arabic language, for a person who is balanced in character and appearance, the root "sawa" is used. Therefore, what is meant by "sawa" in these verses is the completion of physical creation and the refinement of the body's external creation. After creating the body, which is balanced, God breathes a soul into that body, which, due to its honor and higher status, He attributes to Himself. This kind of attribution is called "honorific attribution"; just as the mosque and Ka'bah, due to their importance and higher position, are called "the House of God."

So far we have discussed the Qur'anic viewpoint that considers humans to have two dimensions: soul and body; but the Qur'an presents another matter, which is that the reality and actuality of humanity is that very soul; a soul that is accompanied by a material body. At the time of death, the human soul is taken from the body. And also

after death, the soul remains and continues its life in the world of barzakh, even though after a while the material body disintegrates. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"God takes the souls at the time of their death." (Qur'an 39:42)

"Say, 'The angel of death will take you who has been entrusted with you. Then to your Lord you will be returned.'" (Qur'an 32:11)

The word "tawaffa" in these verses means taking and seizing. Undoubtedly, the angel of death, at the time of death, takes the human soul, because the human body remains. From this statement it becomes clear that the reality of humanity is that very soul, and humans have no reality other than it. If the soul constituted half of humanity and human personality, instead of "yatawaffakum," the noble Qur'an would have said "yatawaffa ba'dhakum." Therefore, the reality of humanity is nothing but what the angel of death takes, and after the soul is taken, nothing of the human reality remains on earth.

Some verses speak about martyrs and explicitly state that martyrs are alive and benefit from divine blessings in the presence of their Lord, even though their material bodies have disintegrated. Therefore, the reality upon which human life depends is that very soul that remains:

"And never think of those who have been killed in the cause of God as dead. Rather, they are alive with their Lord, receiving provision." (Qur'an 3:169)

From these verses it becomes clear that first, humans consist of two dimensions: material body and immaterial soul, and second, the reality of humanity is that very immaterial soul that the angel of death takes at the time of death.

Philosophers have also established numerous proofs for the immateriality of the soul. One of them is that when we pay attention to ourselves, meaning that very perceiving "I," we find that the existence of "I," which is the reality of humanity, is simple and indivisible, and it cannot be divided into "two halves of I," whereas the most fundamental characteristic of bodies is divisibility, and this characteristic is not found in our "I" or soul. Even following the body, it is not divisible. Therefore, if our soul were material, we should be able to divide it into two parts; therefore, necessarily, the soul will be immaterial. Therefore, humans, apart from the material body, have another reality called the soul, and this reality distinguishes humans from other animals, and all humans possess it. When we contemplate our soul, we find two dimensions in it: cognitive and dispositional.

1. The Cognitive Dimension of Humanity

The cognitive dimension of humanity operates in two domains: theoretical and practical. If the object of knowledge is things as they are or will be, it is called the domain of theoretical knowledge; but if the object of knowledge is human action in terms of good and bad, or oughts and ought-nots, it is called the domain of practical knowledge. Therefore, philosophers have divided sciences into theoretical and practical sciences, or theoretical and practical wisdom. Of course, their distinction is in the object of knowledge, not in the faculty of knowledge.

Theoretical Cognition

Knowledge that is acquired by humans is either through mental forms and concepts, such as a human knowing a tree in front of them, from which a form is produced in their mind, which is called acquired knowledge; or there is no such intermediary, and humans are directly aware of the object of knowledge or its actual and real existence, which is called presential knowledge, such as human awareness of their psychological states and feelings and emotions. When we become afraid, we directly and immediately perceive this psychological state, not that we know it through a form or mental concept. When we decide on something, we are immediately aware of our decision and will; our awareness of our own essence and also awareness of our cognitive faculties is also of this kind of awareness.

Sometimes the object of presential knowledge is God and matters related to God, which is also called mystical intuition. The great infallibles, like Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), before seeing things, see God; as narrated from that noble one:

"I do not worship a God I do not see; of course, not with the eye of the head, but with the eye of the heart."

Therefore, Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), before observing things, sees God, and then, in the light of seeing God, becomes aware of things.

Faculties of Acquired Knowledge

Sensory faculties: Many mental forms reach us through the senses. Through the sense of sight, we see things; through the sense of hearing, we hear sounds; through the sense of taste, we taste flavors; through the sense of smell, we perceive scents; and through the sense of touch, we feel things. From all these channels, forms are produced in the mind.

Faculty of intellect: This faculty has the ability to perceive universal concepts, such as the concept of human, book, student, which possess the characteristic of universality. The intellect, through reasoning, syllogism, and proof, reaches new knowledge. Mathematics and philosophy are clear examples of rational knowledge. In mathematics,

humans, through knowledge they possess and with the help of reasoning, become aware of new knowledge, and of course, the new knowledge can be sensory or non-sensory. We all infer a person's level of knowledge and awareness from the precision and scholarly nature of an author's book, just as from the precise order and harmony of the world, we infer a wise and knowledgeable Ordainer who exists beyond the world. Such knowledge is called rational knowledge.

Practical Cognition

Knowledge that relates to the domain of action, meaning oughts and ought-nots and goods and bads, is called the domain of practical knowledge, such as "justice is good" or "humans should tell the truth." In other words, practical wisdom is knowledge of human duties and obligations. Educational sciences and schools of education are part of the collection of practical knowledge or wisdom, because they relate to human action.

2. The Dispositional Dimension of Humanity

In addition to the cognitive dimension, the human soul has another dimension called the dispositional dimension. The dispositional dimension consists of those inclinations that are innate in the human soul. Every human inherently benefits from these inclinations—although at a very weak and latent level—and perceives them self-evidently within themselves. These inclinations did not arise due to external factors, environmental and societal suggestions, or upbringing. Of course, external factors are effective in their growth and flourishing, such as the desire for knowledge and worshipping God.

Human inclinations can be divided into two categories:

1. Animal inclinations: These inclinations are common between animals and humans. Examples of them are: inclination to self-preservation and protection, and desire for the opposite sex. These inclinations are also called instincts.

2. Human inclinations: These are inclinations and tendencies that are specific to humans, or at least their signs are observed less in animals.

Among the genuine human inclinations is love and affection for God, which is inseparable from humans, to the extent that humans can be called theistic or religious beings. God has created humans with a religious and divine nature, and there is no change in God's creation. For this reason, Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says:

"O Lord! You have created hearts upon love of You."

If love and affection for God is mixed with human existence, then its separation from their existence is impossible. Of course, humans may, due to environmental conditions, be heedless of this innate inclination for a while, or err in recognizing its true object; but when obstacles are removed and they become alert, this inclination appears again and shows its true instance. Therefore, the duty of prophets is to awaken and arouse the treasures of human nature, so that they give human religious inclination its proper direction.

Chapter Two: Faith

A) The Meaning of Faith

Faith is a spiritual matter and a state of the soul whose place is the human heart. True recognition of spiritual and psychological matters, like sorrow and joy and hope, is possible through presential knowledge. Humans must feel them, and their true reality cannot be revealed with verbal definitions. Only through understanding their requirements can we somewhat understand their nature. Everyone judges the goodness of justice and the badness of oppression. Sometimes, instead of defining a concept with clearer words and concepts, examples are mentioned as specimens so that the concept becomes clear. We also use this method.

"Iman" (faith) linguistically is a verbal noun from the form if'al and from the root amn (to be safe, secure), which means the settling of belief in the heart, or confirmation of something with certainty, and also trust in something or someone. In both meanings, the concept of safety is involved. A person with faith has such confidence and certainty that they never doubt their belief, and in other words, they are safe from doubt and uncertainty. From Imam Rida (peace be upon him), it is narrated regarding the definition of faith:

"Faith is confirmation of the heart, confession of the tongue, and action with the limbs and organs."

From the linguistic meaning, it appears that belief and heartfelt confirmation in something or someone is called faith, and the person possessing faith is called "mu'min" (believer). When the word faith is used in technical terminology, a specific meaning is intended, which is belief and heartfelt confirmation in God, the Day of Resurrection, heavenly books, angels, and prophets—in other words, matters of the unseen. One who has heartfelt belief and confirmation in all these matters and is committed to them in practice is called a "believer."

To better understand faith, we must know: what is the relationship between faith and knowledge, action, and will?

1. Faith and Knowledge

From the Qur'anic perspective, faith is based on knowledge and understanding; but it is not the case that if knowledge and understanding exist, faith necessarily follows. How many people have knowledge and understanding but lack faith? Thus, faith does not mean knowledge, but it is based on it, because faith in what we do not know is meaningless.

The Qur'an mentions examples where knowledge exists but faith does not:

1. When the Children of Israel saw the clear miracles of Prophet Moses (peace be upon him), they denied them and said: this is clear magic. The Qur'an then says:

"And they rejected them, while their [inner] selves were convinced thereof, out of injustice and haughtiness." (Qur'an 27:14)

From this verse, it becomes clear that the Children of Israel, while they had knowledge and certainty about the miracles of Prophet Moses (peace be upon him) and knew that these clear miracles were from God and that Prophet Moses (peace be upon him) was His prophet, due to their spirit of superiority-seeking and oppression, they denied them.

2. Satan, although aware of God's greatness and worshipped God for thousands of years, ultimately lost his faith and took the path of disbelief and obstinacy, and began to mislead people.

On the other hand, the Qur'an considers faith to be based on knowledge, and thus, from the Qur'anic viewpoint, faith without knowledge has no reward or value. The following noble verse unveils this truth:

"There shall be no compulsion in [acceptance of] the religion. The right course has become clear from the wrong. So whoever disbelieves in Taghut and believes in God has grasped the most trustworthy handhold." (Qur'an 2:256)

The subject of disbelief and faith in this verse is raised after the clarification and recognition of the right path from falsehood; meaning faith without recognition is not feasible.

According to another verse, divine fear, which is a requirement of faith, results from knowledge and awareness of God:

"Only those fear God, from among His servants, who have knowledge." (Qur'an 35:28)

In Islam, faith is based on recognition and knowledge; but in Christianity, humans must first believe in order to understand, not first understand and then believe.

2. Faith and Reason

From Islam's perspective, religious faith is not incompatible with reason, and in the philosophy of religion, when the discussion of faith and reason is raised, what is meant is the relationship between faith and reason, which, due to its importance, we briefly address.

Islam believes that reason and religion are two divine gifts that God has bestowed upon humanity, and through reason and religion, humans can attain eternal happiness. Reason confirms religion, and religion confirms reason. To clarify this truth, it is appropriate to refer to some verses and narrations about reason:

The noble Qur'an considers the revelation of the Qur'an to be for reflection:

"We have sent it down as an Arabic Qur'an that you might use reason." (Qur'an 12:2)

In another verse, it considers the worst of creatures to be those who do not use reason:

"Indeed, the worst of living creatures in the sight of God are the deaf and dumb who do not use reason." (Qur'an 8:22)

In another verse, it says:

"And they will say, 'If only we had been listening or reasoning, we would not be among the companions of the Blaze.'" (Qur'an 67:10)

In another verse, it reproaches those who followed their fathers without reasoning:

"And when it is said to them, 'Follow what God has revealed,' they say, 'Rather, we will follow that which we found our fathers doing.' Even though their fathers understood nothing, nor were they guided?" (Qur'an 2:170)

Islamic narrations also give great importance to reason and reasoning, to the extent that they consider reason as the inner proof and guide of the believer.

1. Imam Kadhimi (peace be upon him) says to Hisham:

"O Hisham! Indeed God has two proofs over people: an apparent proof and a hidden proof. As for the apparent, they are the Messengers, Prophets, and Imams (peace be upon them). As for the hidden, they are the intellects."

2. Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) says:

"The intellect is the guide of the believer."

Also in another narration, he says:

"Whoever has intellect has religion, and whoever has religion enters Paradise."

From these verses and narrations, it becomes clear that Islam has given great importance to reason and reasoning. Also, the selection of religion and following it is

done through reason. It is through reason and rational reasoning that humans consider following religion to be happiness-giving. It does not seem that any Islamic sect has completely denied reason. The difference is only in the scope and domain of reason's function. Therefore, religious people of any school and doctrine benefit from reason to varying degrees; but some more and some less. It should not go unmentioned that following reason is different from being content with reason and abandoning revelation, or what is called rationality minus revelation.

3. Faith and Action

From Islam's perspective, there is a close connection between faith and action, although conceptually they are distinct. In some narrations regarding faith and action, it is stated that God does not accept one without the other. Also, from narrations it appears that action is the outward manifestation of faith, and if there is no action, it becomes apparent that faith has not taken root in the heart. For this reason, in numerous verses, faith and righteous action are mentioned together. Therefore, faith without action is not true and salvific faith. Also in some narrations, action is counted among the pillars of faith. The Qur'an says about those who in no way commit to the practical requirements of their faith:

"The bedouins say, 'We have believed.' Say, 'You have not [yet] believed; but say [instead], 'We have submitted,' for faith has not yet entered your hearts.'" (Qur'an 49:14)

But what is the minimum level of faith? A man asked Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) this very question. The Imam (peace be upon him) replied: "That a person testify to God's oneness and the servitude and prophethood of Muhammad (peace be upon him), accept obedience to truth, and recognize the Imam of their time. If they do so, they are a believer."

However, the true faith that causes human happiness is faith accompanied by action.

Imam Baqir (peace be upon him) narrates from Imam Ali (peace be upon him) that a man asked him: "Is everyone who testifies to God's oneness and the prophethood of the Prophet a believer?"

He said: "Then what about divine obligations?"

It is also narrated that Imam Ali (peace be upon him) says:

"If faith were only uttering the two testimonies, fasting, prayer, and no halal and haram would have been legislated."

From these statements, it becomes clear that faith is a reality with different levels that begins from the minimum and progresses to the most complete.

So far we have addressed the relationship between faith and action and clarified that if true faith takes root in a person's heart, it is always accompanied by action; but now we turn to the relationship between action and faith. Does every action indicate faith?

In response, it can be said that not every action with any intention indicates faith. The Qur'an says about action without faith:

"The example of those who disbelieve in their Lord is [that] their deeds are like ashes which the wind blows forcefully on a stormy day; they are unable [to keep] from what they earned a [single] thing." (Qur'an 14:18)

Meaning, action without faith before God is like ash that on a stormy day, no trace of it remains. Such actions have no value before God.

In another verse, the Qur'an likens the actions of disbelievers to a mirage that has no reality:

"But those who disbelieved - their deeds are like a mirage in a lowland which a thirsty one thinks is water." (Qur'an 24:39)

4. Faith and Free Will

Humans clearly know that they have freedom and free will in their actions. They first evaluate the action, then undertake that action, and after the action, they are pleased or regretful. This process indicates human free will. The Qur'an in numerous verses considers humans as having free will and responsible for their actions. Essentially, the reproach and praise of actions and deserving punishment and reward for behavior indicates free will.

Faith in God is also included in this general rule. Humans, of their own free will, have faith in God or disbelieve. If they have faith, they deserve praise, and if they become disbelievers, they deserve reproach. Faith is not like knowledge, which sometimes comes to a person without free will. God in numerous verses clearly states that faith is a matter of free will. For example, He says:

"And say, 'The truth is from your Lord, so whoever wills - let him believe; and whoever wills - let him disbelieve.'" (Qur'an 18:29)

From this verse, it becomes clear that faith and disbelief are two voluntary matters. Humans can, through contemplation and reflection, have faith in the true religion and

secure their worldly and otherworldly happiness, and they can, of their own free will, disbelieve and deny God's religion and the path of guidance, and write a catastrophic destiny for themselves.

Also, God in the Qur'an explicitly reproaches disbelief, and this itself shows that the denial of faith is a matter of free will; otherwise, reproaching involuntary actions is meaningless:

"Indeed, those who deny Our verses and are arrogant toward them - the gates of Heaven will not be opened for them, nor will they enter Paradise until a camel enters into the eye of a needle." (Qur'an 7:40)

The conclusion is that faith and disbelief are two voluntary matters, and humans must, through contemplation and reflection, choose the best path—which is the true acceptance of faith.

B) Objects of Faith

The Qur'an mentions many objects of faith, but all of them can be traced back to monotheism and faith in God; meaning belief in prophethood, resurrection, imamate, the Qur'an, divine books, etc., are requirements of faith in God.

Since God is the Lord of humanity and one of His attributes is wisdom, according to the requirement of lordship and wisdom, it is necessary that He send prophets to guide humans. Thus, faith in God entails faith in the prophets. Faith in the divine book, angels, and imamate are requirements of faith in prophethood. And since God is just and wise, He requires that He give each person reward and punishment appropriate to their actions. And this reward and punishment is only possible on the Day of Resurrection. Also, God's wisdom requires that the world not be limited to this material world; rather, apart from this material world, another world must come into being that follows this world.

The Qur'an in several verses has enumerated the objects of faith, some of which are: 1. Faith in God; 2. Faith in the Hereafter; 3. Faith in the prophethood of the Prophet of Islam and past prophets; 4. Faith in the Qur'an and previous divine books; 5. Faith in angels; 6. Faith in imamate; 7. Faith in the unseen world.

Among these objects, faith in God, faith in prophethood, and faith in resurrection have special importance and are considered principles of religion, and other objects are requirements of belief in these principles, and as stated, they are all requirements of faith in God. For this reason, the Prophet (peace be upon him) says:

"Say: There is no god but God, and you will succeed."

One of the objects is faith in the unseen world; but what is the unseen? The unseen world stands opposite the witnessed world. The world that we perceive through the senses is called the "world of witness" or "sensible world"; but the unseen world cannot be perceived through the senses; rather, one must believe in its existence through reason or intuition and spiritual vision. Faith in the unseen world actually separates the religious perspective from the atheistic and materialistic perspective. Humans can penetrate this world through rational contemplation and spiritual intuition and prove the existence of some of its attributes through reason, and through spiritual vision, they can progress further into this world. For this reason, the Qur'an has considered the place of faith to be the human heart.

C) Levels of Faith

As mentioned, faith is a reality with different levels, and it is not the case that people of faith are equal in their level of faith. The stronger a person's faith, the higher their existential capacity rises and the more happiness they attain. Therefore, humans should strive to strengthen their faith. The highest level of faith is when a person reaches the level of infallibility and has no goal except God's pleasure. Since faith is based on knowledge and its manifestation is righteous action, the deeper a believer's knowledge becomes and the more righteous action they perform, the more solid their faith becomes.

Islamic texts clearly speak of the existence of different levels of faith. Among them are:

"The believers are only those who, when God is mentioned, their hearts become fearful, and when His verses are recited to them, it increases them in faith; and upon their Lord they rely." (Qur'an 8:2)

In this verse, when God's verses are recited to believers, it increases their faith.

"It is He who sent down tranquility into the hearts of the believers that they would increase in faith along with their [present] faith." (Qur'an 48:4)

According to this verse, God sends down tranquility, which means peace and tranquility of heart, upon the hearts of believers to save them from doubt and fear and horror in the storm of events and to receive a greater share of faith.

The narrations of the infallible Imams (peace be upon them) also testify that faith has levels and degrees. Among them is a narration that Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) has said:

"Faith is like a ladder that has ten rungs, and its rungs are traversed one after another."

As mentioned, from verses and narrations it becomes clear that the reality of faith has levels, and humans should strive at every moment to strengthen their faith and not be content with the preliminary steps of faith, and to raise themselves to the summit and peak of the ascent of faith.

For a believer to strengthen their faith, they should observe the following matters:

1. Completely submit to God's commands and prohibitions; not that they believe in some rulings and disbelieve in others;
2. Acquire knowledge about the objects of faith and continuously increase this knowledge, find firm and clear proofs for it, and if faced with doubts, remove them with clear proofs;
3. Pay more attention to the objects of faith and constantly remember God and the resurrection;
4. Strive to be committed to the requirements of faith. If they have faith that God oversees human actions and conduct, they should not sin before such a God, and if they know that on the Day of Resurrection, all of a person's good and bad deeds will be examined, they should constantly remember the account of the Day of Resurrection so as not to let the desires of the self overcome them and trample God's command;
5. Do not contaminate their faith with oppression and observe the rights of others;
6. By purifying the self, strengthen the ground for the growth of faith within themselves.

Part Two: The Origin (Mabda')

Chapter One: Proving God's Existence

Undoubtedly, one of the most fundamental and important topics that has always occupied human thought, and the central subject of all religions, is the existence of God. Regarding the proof of God's existence, there are different views. Some Muslim philosophers and theologians consider God's existence to be self-evident and not in need of proof, or in other words, "innate" (fitri), and they support this view with the Quran and narrations from the Infallibles. The Quran states in this regard:

"Is there doubt about Allah, Creator of the heavens and the earth?" (Quran 14:10)

"So direct your face toward the religion, inclining to truth. [Adhere to] the fitrah of Allah upon which He has created [all] people. No change should there be in the creation of Allah. That is the correct religion, but most people do not know." (Quran 30:30)

Imam Ali (peace be upon him) addresses the divine presence in a narration:

"O Allah! You created hearts with love for You and You shaped minds with knowledge of You."

In Imam Hussain's Arafah prayer, it states:

"How can we prove You through something that depends on You for its existence? Does anything other than You have a manifestation that You lack, so that it could manifest You? When have You ever been absent that You would need evidence and proof? When have You been distant that traces and signs would lead us to You?"

From these verses and narrations, Islamic thinkers have concluded that God's existence is more self-evident than anything else.

On the other hand, some philosophers and theologians believe that God's existence is not self-evident and requires reasoning and proof. Yet others, while acknowledging the self-evidence of God's existence, consider proofs and reasoning to be a means of alerting and drawing attention to this self-evident matter.

In this text, for the sake of brevity, we will refer to three proofs for God's existence: the argument from fitrah (innate nature), the causal argument, and the argument from design.

A) The Argument from Fitrah (Innate Nature)

There are two ways to know God's existence: journey through the horizons (afaq) and journey within oneself (anfus), as the Noble Quran indicates:

"We will show them Our signs in the horizons and within themselves until it becomes clear to them that it is the truth." (Quran 41:53)

Through the journey in the horizons, humans observe creation and reflect on the temporal nature, contingency, and order of phenomena, thereby recognizing the existence of a wise and powerful Creator. However, through the journey within oneself, one discovers an intuitive and immediate knowledge of God in their heart and bows in reverence before such a God who is absolute perfection. This inner path can be termed "the way of fitrah." The Quran and narrations of the Imams have pointed to this path, but first we must explain the meaning of fitrah and the characteristics of innate matters.

1. The Meaning of Fitrah

The root word "fatar" originally means beginning or starting, which is why it also means creation—because creating something means bringing it into existence and initiating its being.

Based on this, fitrah can be defined as a special state of the beginning of existence, or in other words, a type of creation. Things can be considered fitri (innate) when the creation of a being necessitates them and they have the following three characteristics:

First: They are found in all individuals of that species, although their intensity and weakness may vary.

Second: They are constant and unchanging—not having one requirement in one period of history and a different one in another period, as the Quran states:

"[Adhere to] the fitrah of Allah upon which He has created people. No change should there be in the creation of Allah." (Quran 30:30)

Third: They do not need teaching and learning, although their strengthening, reminder, or directing attention to them may require instruction and reasoning.

Human innate matters can be divided into two categories:

- a) Innate knowledge that every human possesses without needing to learn.
- b) Innate inclinations and tendencies that are inherent in every person's creation.

Therefore, if there is a type of knowledge of God that is constant for every person and needs no teaching or learning, it can be called "innate knowledge of God" (fitri knowledge of God), just as the tendency toward God can be called "innate worship of God."

2. The Fitrah of Seeking God

Seeking God speaks of the inner human tendency toward God. Humans are created in such a way that they seek God.

The Quran refers to this matter in a verse stating that God made a covenant with the children of Adam not to worship Satan but to worship God. Worshipping God is a type of seeking God:

"Did I not enjoin upon you, O children of Adam, that you not worship Satan - [for] indeed, he is to you a clear enemy - And that you worship [only] Me? This is a straight path." (Quran 36:60-61)

The Quran also explicitly states in a verse that all those in the heavens and earth prostrate to God, and prostrating to God is a type of seeking God:

"And to Allah prostrates whoever is within the heavens and the earth, willingly or by compulsion, and their shadows [as well] in the mornings and the afternoons." (Quran 13:15)

This seeking of God may diminish due to wrong education, environmental and genetic influences, but it does not disappear and will manifest again in certain situations and conditions. The Quran states in this regard:

"And when they board a ship, they invoke Allah, sincere to Him in religion. But when He delivers them to the land, at once they associate others with Him." (Quran 29:65)

This verse shows that the Children of Israel, during difficulties and despair, call upon God sincerely and are drawn to Him. In reality, the cutting off of hope causes humans to turn to the ultimate Cause. However, when they reach a safe environment, they place hope in others and practice polytheism.

There are numerous narrations on this subject, one of which we'll mention as an example. Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) says:

"Allah is the One to whom all creatures turn during their needs, hardships, and when they despair of everything else."

B) The Causal Argument

One of the ways to prove God's existence is through the causal argument, whereby we recognize God's existence through the contingency of the universe. This argument can be briefly stated as follows: The universe is an effect, and every effect needs a cause. Therefore, the universe needs a cause which is either God or ultimately leads to God. Thus, God exists.

We will present this argument in several points:

1. Definition of Cause and Effect

If we compare two existents and see that "A" is an existent upon which the realization of another existent "B" depends, we call the existence of "A" the cause and the existence of "B" the effect. This definition is the general definition of cause, which includes conditions, preparatory factors, and other incomplete causes. However, cause also has a specific meaning which is: an existent whose presence makes the realization and existence of another existent necessary. This cause is also called the "complete cause."

Here, the cause is such that it is sufficient for the realization of the effect's existence. Otherwise, the cause is called an "incomplete cause." For example, the existence of heat depends on and is contingent upon the existence of fire, and thus we call the existence of heat an effect and fire a cause.

Humans have become aware of the principle of causality through their nature and observation of their inner selves. They see their mental and psychological activities and creations as things that originate from them, and they consider their existence as dependent on themselves, while they do not consider themselves dependent on these activities. With this observation, they extract the concept of cause and effect and attribute it to other existents.

Philosophers consider cause to be of four types: efficient cause, final cause, formal cause, and material cause. The efficient cause is that from which the effect comes into being, and the final cause is the motive of the agent for performing the action. The material cause is the ground for the emergence of the effect and remains within it, like the elements constituting a plant. The formal cause is the form and actuality that appears in matter and becomes the source of new effects, like the vegetative form.

The efficient cause has two technical meanings: one is the natural agent used in physics and natural sciences, which is the source of motion and change in bodies and states; the other is the divine agent discussed in philosophy and theology, meaning an

existent that brings the effect into being and gives it existence. In this argument, when we discuss the efficient cause, we mean the divine efficient cause.

2. Proving the Contingency of the Universe

Since the criterion for an effect's need for a cause is its existential weakness, every poor and weak existent needs a cause. Existential weakness has effects and signs by which we can recognize the contingency of an existent. Among these are: temporal limitation, limitation of effects, dependence on others, susceptibility to change and motion, and perishability.

An existent that undergoes change undoubtedly has existential poverty. Consequently, it is an effect, because change is a sign of deficiency and lack. It is obvious that an existent with deficiency and lack cannot remove its own deficiency; rather, it needs a cause to bring it from potentiality to actuality.

An existent with temporal and spatial limitations definitely has existential poverty and consequently will be an effect, because it either has a past of non-existence or a future of non-existence. An existent that has dependence on others in some way has existential weakness and consequently is an effect. Given these characteristics, it becomes clear that since the world is the arena of change and transformations, and the existents of this world have both past and future non-existence, and its parts are interdependent, therefore the world is an effect. This is why Imam Ali (peace be upon him) says:

"Everything other than God is an effect."

"Everything has existence through Him."

Imam Ali (peace be upon him) also, in certain expressions, negates certain attributes exclusively from God, and from this we understand that everything other than God possesses these attributes. These attributes are necessities of being an effect, which include:

- The passage of time does not change Him
- He has no spatial limitations
- His state does not change
- Rest and motion do not occur in Him
- God has no similar or equal by which He could be known
- God neither begets nor is begotten
- Decline and decay have no way to Him

3. The Impossibility of Circular Reasoning and Infinite Regress

Some critics of the causal argument say: What problem is there if the chain of causes continues infinitely, or if the universe is the cause of itself? In this case, God cannot be proven.

Philosophers have responded to this objection that infinite regress of causes is impossible. In the view of these philosophers, the impossibility of infinite regress is either self-evident or at least close to self-evident, and they have provided proofs for this impossibility, to which we will refer as an example:

If we assume a series of causes and effects where each cause is the effect of another cause, we will have a chain of dependencies and relationships. It is obvious that dependent existence cannot be realized without an independent existence that is the object of that dependency. Therefore, there must necessarily be, beyond this chain of dependencies and relationships, an independent existence in whose light they all are realized; because an infinite collection of needy and dependent things will never become independent, self-sufficient, and rich.

As for whether this world can be the cause of itself—which is technically called the "impossibility of circularity"—we must say that circularity means that the existential cause of an existent is itself; meaning the existence of an existent depends on itself. This necessitates that the existent be prior to itself, and this requires the combination of contradictions. That is, an existent, because it is its own cause, must be prior to itself, and because it is an effect, it must not be prior to itself but rather subsequent to itself. The combination of contradictions is also impossible. Therefore, we cannot assume that the world is the cause of itself, but rather it needs a cause outside itself, which is God. The Quran has also rejected in the form of a rhetorical question that something could be the cause of its own creation:

"Or were they created by nothing, or were they the creators [of themselves]?" (Quran 52:35)

C) The Argument from Design

The argument from design is one of the most common arguments presented for God's existence. This argument has a history as long as human existence. From ancient times, humans have observed the orderly and harmonious phenomena of the world and asked themselves: What is the cause of this order and harmony? Have the parts themselves cooperatively created this order, or has a wise and deliberate Designer ordered them? These two theories have had followers. Most humans have believed that by studying phenomena and the order of the world, one can see the powerful hand of God behind it all. Therefore, one of the ways to reach God's existence is through the

order governing existence. Divine prophets have also greatly emphasized the argument from design.

The Noble Quran also greatly values the argument from design and invites people to think about the complex creation of beings, the heavens, the earth, and the mountains. It considers the indication of order for an Orderer to be so obvious that it says, just remind them; meaning humans can see the powerful hand of the all-knowing and wise God with the slightest attention—if they wish. The Quran states:

"Then do they not look at the camels - how they are created? And at the sky - how it is raised? And at the mountains - how they are erected? And at the earth - how it is spread out? So remind, [O Muhammad]; you are only a reminder. You are not over them a controller." (Quran 88:17-22)

And in another verse it says:

"Indeed, within the heavens and earth are signs for the believers. And in the creation of yourselves and what He disperses of moving creatures are signs for people who are certain [in faith]. And [in] the alternation of night and day and [in] what Allah sends down from the sky of provision and gives life thereby to the earth after its lifelessness and [in His] directing of the winds are signs for a people who reason. These are the verses of Allah which We recite to you in truth. Then in what statement after Allah and His verses will they believe?" (Quran 45:3-6)

Imam Ali (peace be upon him) also greatly emphasized the argument from design, referring to the life and creation of many creatures such as ants and peacocks, describing the subtleties of their creation, and essentially drawing people's attention to the fact that by thinking and reflecting on the creation of beings, one can recognize the wise and deliberate God.

Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) also says about the order of creation:

"How strange is a creature who thinks God is hidden from the eyes of His servants, while he sees the effects of His workmanship in the mind-bewildering composition and decisive arrangement of his own creation. By my life, if they thought about this great matter—like the manifest composition of the world and the apparent subtlety of its management, the emergence of creatures from non-existence, and their transformation from one nature to another and from one form to another—they would witness evidence of the existence of a Maker. For there is no phenomenon except that it contains traces of management and composition that indicate a managing Creator, and its deliberate composition guides humans to the One, Wise God."

From all these statements, it becomes clear that thinking about the orderly and complex structure of the beings of the world causes humans to acknowledge a wise and knowledgeable Orderer.

The argument from design can be presented in various forms, all of which have a common core, which can be stated as follows:

1. The Common Structure of the Argument from Design

First premise: The natural world is an orderly phenomenon, or there are orderly phenomena in the world.

Second premise: Based on rational self-evidence, every order originates from a wise and conscious Orderer who, with knowledge and awareness, has arranged the parts of the orderly phenomenon with harmony and special arrangement to achieve a specific goal. Therefore, the natural world has come into being through the design and management of a conscious Orderer.

But before we refer to different formulations of the argument from design, let us define order.

2. Definition of Order

Order is one of the concepts that has a clear meaning and is used in contrast to chaos and confusion. An orderly phenomenon is a collection whose parts are related to each other in such a way that they all pursue a single, specific goal. In other words, order is the gathering of different parts with specific quality and quantity in a collection such that their cooperation and harmony pursue a certain goal.

If we examine orderly collections carefully, it becomes clear that three elements constitute the essential components of the concept of order:

First: Precise design and planning Second: Calculated organization Third: Purposefulness

3. Formulation of the Argument from Design

The argument from design can be presented in two forms: the argument from purposefulness and the argument from harmony in the entire universe. There are other forms for formulating the argument from design that we will not discuss.

The Argument from Purposefulness

In this argument, emphasis is placed on the purposefulness of orderly beings. We observe that orderly phenomena are constantly moving toward a goal. On the other hand, we know that something without knowledge and awareness cannot move toward a goal unless a knowledgeable, intelligent, and managing being guides it. We also know that beings themselves lack knowledge and awareness. Therefore, a knowledgeable and managing being guides them toward their goal. Examples of these orderly beings can be both animals and plants.

The Noble Quran refers to this formulation of the argument from design in verses, stating that it is God who, through His guidance, so manages that plants always produce pleasant fruits:

"And it is He who sends down rain from the sky, and We produce thereby the growth of all things. We produce from it greenery from which We produce grains arranged in layers. And from the palm trees - of its emerging fruit are clusters hanging low. And [We produce] gardens of grapevines and olives and pomegranates, similar yet varied. Look at [each of] its fruit when it yields and [at] its ripening. Indeed in that are signs for a people who believe." (Quran 6:99)

Imam Ali (peace be upon him) has also referred to this formulation in certain expressions:

"In Your hand is the forelock of every creature, and to You is the return of every soul."

From these verses and narrations, it clearly appears that there is a wise and knowledgeable Guide behind the beings of this world who guides them toward their goal.

The Argument from Harmony

This formulation of the argument from design emphasizes the harmony and order of the entire universe to prove a wise Orderer for the entire universe. This type of harmony can be proven through the connection and compatibility of the parts of the universe with each other.

The advancement of experimental sciences has shown that the parts of the universe are so compatibly arranged that they have made life possible. If the distance of the sun were less or more than the limit set for it, the continuation of life would not be possible. The verses of the Noble Quran and the narrations of the Infallible Imams testify to this truth. Imam Ali (peace be upon him) says:

"So God began creation... and made the opposing parts compatible with each other."

Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) also says in this regard:

"O Mufaddal! The first lesson and evidence for the Creator—Glory be to Him—is giving form to this world and gathering its parts and creating order in it. Therefore, if you think deeply and profoundly about the world with thought and intellect, you will surely find it like a house or abode where all the needs of God's servants have been prepared and gathered. All of this is evidence that the universe has been created with precise measurement, wisdom, order, proportion, and harmony. Its Creator is One, and He is the Form-Giver, Order-Maker, and Harmonizer of its parts."

From these statements, it clearly appears that the world is a harmonious collection that has been adorned with wisdom, knowledge, and management, and this Harmonizer and Order-Giver is none other than God. If there were a god other than the One God, the world would be destroyed:

"Had there been within the heavens and earth gods besides Allah, they both would have been ruined." (Quran 21:22)

In this verse, God's existence has been proven in the form of proof by contradiction. The form of this proof is as follows:

1. If there had been gods in the heavens and earth other than Allah, corruption would have occurred in creation.
2. There is no corruption in creation.

Therefore: There are no gods in the heavens and earth except God.

Chapter Two: The Attributes of God

A) Ways of Knowing God's Attributes

Complete comprehension of God's essence and attributes is not possible for humans; but humans can find an opening to the divine realm through various paths and gain some knowledge of that transcendent realm. Those paths are: 1. The rational path; 2. Contemplation of horizons and souls; 3. The Qur'an and narrations; 4. Discovery and intuition.

1. The Rational Path

Reason can prove the existence of a being who is Self-Sufficient in essence. When it attains this, it also gains the ability to prove many of God's affirmative and negative attributes, because any attribute that would cause deficiency in the essence of the Self-Sufficient Being must be negated from Him. Khwajah Nasiruddin Tusi, in the book *Tajrid al-I'tiqad*, has benefited from this method to prove many negative and affirmative attributes, some of which we mention:

Khwajah Nasiruddin states that the necessity of God's existence leads us to several conclusions:

- God Almighty has always been and will remain, because the Necessarily Existent is that for whom existence is necessary; therefore, non-existence is not permissible for Him.
- God has no partner, because if He had a partner, that partner would also be Necessarily Existent, and both would be alike in the necessity of existence. Of course, each would have a characteristic that the other does not have. Therefore, they would be composed of one shared meaning, which is the necessity of existence, and another characteristic specific to each. And composition is a sign of weakness and need; but we know that weakness and need have no way to the realm of the Necessarily Existent. Therefore, God has no partner.
- God is not composite, because the composite needs its parts, and something that is composed of parts, its parts are more deserving of necessity than itself.
- God is not located in space and cannot be pointed to with the senses, because He is not a body, and therefore space and time have no meaning for Him. If God were in space, motion and rest would be attributes of Him, and motion and rest indicate temporality, which contradicts the necessity of existence. Therefore, He is above space and its Creator.
- God does not indwell in anything. Some believe that God indwelled in Christ, and some common Sufis believe that God indwells in the body of the perfected mystic

who has reached God. This belief is false, because God's indwelling necessitates God being spatial and corporeal, and as mentioned, God is neither spatial nor corporeal. Therefore, such indwelling is incorrect.

- God is not united with anything other than Himself, because other than Him is contingent, and it is not permissible for the Self-Sufficient Being to be united with a needy and dependent being, because in this case, He Himself would also become limited.
- God is not in any direction, because He is not a body.
- God is not the locus of temporal events, meaning it is impossible for a new attribute or state to appear in Him, because if they are perfections, God has always been characterized by them, and if they are deficiencies, He has never been characterized by them.
- The Necessarily Existent does not need anyone for any attribute, because other than Him is contingent, and the contingent's entire existence is dependent on God. Now if the Self-Sufficient God were dependent on contingents in His existence or any of His perfections, a vicious circle would result, and a vicious circle is invalid.

Also, it can be said that if God needs other than Himself for an attribute or perfection, He becomes needy, and the necessity of existence is not compatible with neediness.

- God's attributes are not additional to His essence. His real attributes are identical to His essence, because if the attributes were additional to the essence, it would follow that the essence at the level of essence would be devoid of those attributes.
- God cannot be seen with the physical eye, because He is not a body and has no color.
- God has sovereignty and dominion. Sovereignty and kingship are established on three things: being independent of others, others being dependent on Him, and being able to dispose of everything without anyone holding Him accountable. These three conditions exist in God, and consequently He has ownership and sovereignty over everything.
- He is Wise. The wise is one who knows realities well and performs every action in the most perfect manner and according to universal interests, correctly and firmly. God is wise in both senses.
- God is Self-Sustaining (Qayyum). Qayyum means self-sustaining, who needs no one else, and it is others who are dependent on Him.

2. Contemplation of Horizons and Souls

Another path to knowing divine attributes is contemplation of horizons and souls. Through this study, humans can find some divine attributes. For example, from studying and examining the order of the universe, animals, plants, and even humans themselves, it becomes apparent that the Ordainer and Creator of existence, based on the correspondence between cause and effect, must possess the attributes of knowledge, wisdom, and power, and also from the cohesion and unity governing the universe, one can realize the unity and monotheism of the Creator and Ordainer of existence.

This inference is also made based on rational power. The difference between this and the first path is that in the first method, all the premises are rational; but in the second path, some premises are taken from observing the ordered world, and we conclude that the world is ordered.

3. The Qur'an and Narrations

Another path to knowing divine attributes is referring to the Qur'an and authentic narrations of the infallibles (peace be upon them). After the existence of God and some of His attributes, as well as the prophethood and some perfective attributes of the noble Prophet of Islam (peace be upon him) are proven, many divine attributes can be recognized through the Qur'an and narrations of the infallibles (peace be upon them).

4. Discovery and Intuition

As a result of spiritual development and acquisition of spiritual virtues, humans reach a point where they can perceive many realities, including God's attributes of beauty and majesty, through spiritual observation. Of course, this path is difficult and arduous and is exclusive to a few people, but it is a path that can be traversed and reached, and the noble youth of Iran have the ability to traverse it. These four methods are not only used in knowing divine attributes but have application in most Islamic discussions.

The pure rational method is called the "philosophical method," and the method of discovery and intuition is called the "mystical method." The method of using verses and narrations is called the "scriptural method," and when the study of horizons and souls is done through a combination of rational and scriptural methods, the "theological method" has been used.

B) Types of God's Attributes

As mentioned, humans can know God's attributes to the extent of their capability. God's attributes are divided into various types from different perspectives, some of which we mention:

1. Affirmative and Negative Attributes

Among the divisions of divine attributes is the division of attributes into affirmative and negative:

Affirmative attributes are those attributes that express a perfection of God and have an affirmative and existential aspect, and their absence is considered a kind of deficiency, such as knowledge, power, life, etc. This type of attribute, with its affirmative and perfective reality, is a source of beauty and loveliness for the described, and negates any deficiency and imperfection from Him. In this respect, these attributes are also called "attributes of beauty."

Negative attributes are those attributes that negate deficiency and imperfection—such as ignorance—from God. Since deficiency is a kind of negation of perfection, therefore, the negation of the negation of perfection returns to a kind of affirmation and perfection; for example, ignorance means the negation of knowledge, and the negation of its negation is the affirmation of knowledge.

The purpose of negative attributes is to negate the attribution of deficiency and imperfection from God, and ultimately what remains is perfections. Since humans are more familiar with deficiency and limitation, negative attributes are more comprehensible and clearer to them than perfective attributes and lead them more to God's transcendence.

2. Essential and Active Attributes

Affirmative attributes of God can also be divided into essential and active attributes:

Essential attributes are those attributes that are abstracted from the divine essence. These attributes are called "essential" because they are always with the divine essence, and for abstracting them, there is no need to conceive of other beings, and the essence is always characterized by them, such as knowledge, power, and life.

Active attributes of God are those attributes that are abstracted from the relationship of the divine essence with creatures, such as the attribute of creatorship, which is abstracted from the existential dependence of creatures on the divine essence; meaning God is characterized by the attribute of creatorship when we consider Him, creatures, and the existential relationship between them. In this case, the attribute of creatorship is abstracted, and we say God is the Creator of beings.

Likewise is the attribute of providership; when we consider God and creatures and show that God provides the means of their life, this attribute is abstracted. In other words, until

an act called creation and provision is issued from God, He cannot be called Creator and Provider in actuality, although He has essential power over creation and provision.

Thus, if we consider God without creatures, He is not characterized by being Creator and Provider; but in contrast, for abstracting essential attributes, there is no need to suppose creatures or any being other than God.

3. Self and Relational Attributes

Self attributes are those attributes by which the divine essence is characterized without considering any relation or addition to other than the essence, such as divine life, which does not need any relation outside the essence; but relational attributes, in terms of concept, include a kind of addition to other than the essence, such as knowledge and power, which include addition and relation to another thing, meaning "the known" and "the capable." Meaning knowledge of something and power over something are related, and are not used absolutely.

Now we will explain the affirmative essential attributes.

C) Enumeration of Affirmative Essential Attributes

1. Divine Knowledge

Among God's affirmative and essential attributes is knowledge. God is aware of His own essence and all beings; thus, God has knowledge both of His own essence and of beings and creatures before their creation and also after their creation.

God's knowledge can be conceived in three ways:

1. Knowledge of the essence
2. Knowledge of beings and creatures before their creation
3. Knowledge of beings and creatures after their creation

The noble Qur'an states that God has knowledge and awareness of all beings. There are numerous verses in this regard, some of which we consider:

"And God is Knowing of all things." (Qur'an 2:282)

"And with Him are the keys of the unseen; none knows them except Him. And He knows what is on the land and in the sea. Not a leaf falls but that He knows it. And no grain is there within the darknesses of the earth and no moist or dry [thing] but that it is [written] in a clear record." (Qur'an 6:59)

"Say, 'Whether you conceal what is in your breasts or reveal it, God knows it. And He knows that which is in the heavens and that which is on the earth.'" (Qur'an 3:29)

The narrations of the infallibles (peace be upon them) also show that God has knowledge and awareness of all beings. As an example, Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says regarding the extent of divine knowledge:

"Nothing is hidden from God. Not the count of the abundant drops of water, nor the numerous stars of the sky, nor the particles of dust carried by winds in the air, nor the movements of ants on hard rocks, nor the resting places of tiny ants in dark nights. God is aware of where tree leaves fall and the hidden movements of eyes."

At the end of the discussion on divine knowledge, it is worth mentioning that God's seeing and hearing, or being All-Hearing and All-Seeing, returns to His knowledge, because the meaning of being All-Hearing and All-Seeing is nothing but knowledge of audibles and visibles. Therefore, when we say God sees, it means He has knowledge of visible and seeable matters, and when we say God hears, it means He has knowledge of what is audible.

Attention to God's boundless knowledge has amazing effects on human life. In other words, if humans have faith that in every state, God has presential knowledge of them and they are always in the divine presence, they easily abstain from sins, undertake good deeds with greater desire and motivation, never feel loneliness, bewilderment and confusion, and show greater perseverance in the face of worldly difficulties. Belief in divine oversight is also obtained through faith in divine knowledge and awareness of human actions and behavior and plays an important role in self-control and improvement of management.

2. Divine Power

Among God's essential and affirmative attributes is "power," and one of God's names is "the Powerful" (Qadir). Some theologians have defined power as follows: An agent who performs their work with will and free choice is said to have "power" in their work. Therefore, power is the agency of a free agent for a work that may issue from them. The powerful in this sense stands opposite to the compelled agent and what is called the necessitating agent, such as fire that is the source of action but the action of heat and burning does not occur from it through choice and will.

Some others have also defined power as follows: Power is that if the powerful wills, they perform the action, and if they do not will, they do not perform it.

Proofs have been presented for proving the attribute of power, some of which we mention:

- The giver of perfection is not devoid of perfection. Some of God's creatures, including humans, are characterized by the attribute of power, and through this they can create products; whereas humans with all their attributes are God Almighty's creature and effect. Therefore, God Himself must be characterized by the attribute of power to be able to create power in creatures. Imam Ali (peace be upon him) has also referred to this proof and said:

"[And God is] the strength of every weak one."

Every power and strength observed in creatures is from Him, and power in creatures indicates God's power. And one devoid of something cannot be its giver.

- The precision and amazing order of creatures can be proof of both divine knowledge and power, because if God did not have power, He could not create such amazing ordered beings with very precise quality and quantity.

Imam Ali (peace be upon him) has also referred to this truth in his words:

"[God] created creatures by His power."

"The One whose signs testify to His power."

3. Divine Life

Another divine attribute that is affirmative and essential is life. The reality of life, especially divine life, is not clear to humans, but its concept is clear. Therefore, defining it is also very difficult. Theologians who have defined life have not made its reality clear and apparent; rather, they have discussed its requirements.

The noble Qur'an in numerous verses mentions God with the attribute of the Living. For example, it says:

"And rely upon the Ever-Living who does not die, and exalt [God] with His praise." (Qur'an 25:58)

"God - there is no deity except Him, the Ever-Living, the Sustainer of existence." (Qur'an 2:255)

4. Divine Will

Another affirmative and essential attribute of God is will. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"His command is only when He intends a thing that He says to it, 'Be,' and it is." (Qur'an 36:82)

Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him), in response to the question of whether God's knowledge and will are the same or have two different meanings, says: Knowledge is not the same as will; because you can say "I will do such action if God wills," but you do not say "I will do it if God knows."

- Divine will at the level of essence means God's pleasure and satisfaction with His own essence, and at the level of action, it is divine satisfaction with His own action.
- Divine will means the exercise of power and sovereignty.

The fundamental point is that the will of creatures must be purified from the aspect of deficiency and limitation and then applied to God.

Divine will can be considered in two ways: existential will and legislative will. Existential will originates from God's special relationship with creatures, and when God wills something, it necessarily comes to be; but legislative will originates from God's special relationship with some voluntary human actions where there is the possibility of the will diverging from what is willed.

For example, if God wills that a particular being come into existence, it will certainly come into existence; but in legislative will, God has willed that all humans be guided to the straight path. Nevertheless, some humans can violate this matter. Perhaps regarding deviation from legislative will, we can say that it too is in accordance with divine will, because God has created humans with free will.

5. Wisdom

One of God's affirmative attributes is wisdom, and therefore God is Wise and all His actions are wise. Wisdom is used in two senses:

The first meaning of wisdom is that the agent's actions are in the utmost precision, firmness, and perfection, and no deficiency or imperfection finds its way into their action. God is wise in this sense, and all His actions are realized in the best and most complete possible way and are free from any deficiency or imperfection. Divine wisdom in this sense is among the attributes of action and not among the attributes of essence.

The other meaning of wisdom is that the agent's action is not reprehensible and futile. Based on this meaning, when we say God is wise, it means that God does not do ugly, shameful, vain, absurd, and futile work. The attribute of wisdom in this sense is a negative attribute.

The proof for its establishment is as follows: The creation of reprehensible actions or vain and futile ones results from the agent's ignorance, inability, or neediness. Since God is free from all these deficiencies, He never performs ugly and futile work. Consequently, His actions are wise.

Wisdom in this sense—that God does not do reprehensible and futile work—is the foundation of many theological discussions. For example, theologians in theology propose that divine wisdom requires that God send messengers to guide humans. God has created humans for a purpose, and this purpose is nothing but their spiritual and psychological development, and since humans alone cannot attain this goal, God's wisdom requires that prophets be sent so that humans, through their training and teaching, reach their true perfection. The Qur'an has connected the sending of messengers with the attribute of divine wisdom, saying:

"[We sent] messengers as bringers of good tidings and warners so that mankind will have no argument against God after the messengers. And ever is God Exalted in Might and Wise." (Qur'an 4:165)

Also, God's wisdom requires that death not be the end of life, because humans have the capacity for eternal life. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"Then did you think that We created you uselessly and that to Us you would not be returned?" (Qur'an 23:115)

Therefore, the meaning of God's wisdom is that God never performs futile work, and all of God's actions are purposeful. God, to enable beings to reach their desired goal, has prepared all the necessary conditions and appropriate grounds. Of course, the purposefulness of human action differs from God's action. Humans perform an action for a purpose to remove their deficiency and to characterize themselves with a perfection; but God is pure perfection and free from any deficiency and inability, and therefore the purposes of His actions are to bring creatures to their desired perfection, not to remove deficiency from Himself or acquire property.

D) Justice

The attribute of justice, which is among God's attributes of action, has special importance in Islamic thought, to the extent that according to the Imami view, divine justice is counted among the principles of religion and sect, because it forms the foundation of many Imami beliefs. This attribute has a close connection with the attribute of divine wisdom, because one of the meanings of God being wise is that He does not do ugly and reprehensible work, and since oppression is one of the

reprehensible acts, God is pure and exalted from it. Consequently, all of God's actions are characterized by the attribute of justice.

What is meant by justice is placing everything and everyone in their proper place. Imam Ali (peace be upon him), in a narration, defines justice as follows:

"Justice places things in their places."

According to this meaning, God has placed everything and everyone in the world in their proper and deserving place, such that no one's rights are destroyed.

The proof that God never does ugly and oppressive work and that all His actions are characterized by the attribute of justice is that an agent who undertakes ugly and oppressive actions either is not aware of their ugliness, or is in need of oppressive actions to fulfill one of their needs, or undesirable traits such as vindictiveness, envy, and feeling of inferiority have caused such actions. Since none of these factors can be found in God's sacred essence and He is absolute perfection and free from any deficiency or imperfection, God never performs oppressive and ugly actions.

For further clarity, it is appropriate to mention the divisions of divine justice:

1. Existential Justice

The meaning of justice in the existential system or the world of creation is that God in such a system has given each being blessings according to its merit and capacity, and in other words, God has bestowed existence and perfection upon each thing according to the measure of its capacity and merit, and the components of the world have a precise harmony with each other based on fixed laws, such that the order governing beings and the entire creation system is clear testimony to such justice. It is also stated in narrations that the world is established on justice, which refers to existential justice.

2. Legislative Justice

Legislative justice means that the obligations that God has sent down upon people through prophets are based on justice and equity; meaning first, He has sent down all the necessary rulings for human happiness, and second, He has not obligated anyone beyond their capacity and ability, and in other words, He has considered human capability and capacity and has established rulings according to their existential capacity. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"We charge no soul except [with that within] its capacity. And with Us is a record which speaks with truth; and they will not be wronged." (Qur'an 23:62)

3. Retributive Justice

Retributive justice means that God judges justly between people on the Day of Resurrection and does not destroy anyone's rights; meaning He does not judge equally between the righteous and the wicked, and gives each person reward appropriate to their actions. Also, divine retributive justice requires that those to whom no obligation has been communicated not be punished. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And We place the scales of justice for the Day of Resurrection, so no soul will be treated unjustly at all." (Qur'an 21:47)

"Or should we treat those who believe and do righteous deeds like corrupters in the land? Or should We treat the righteous like the wicked?" (Qur'an 38:28)

"And We would not punish until We sent a messenger." (Qur'an 17:15)

Of course, if we consider otherworldly reward and punishment as the embodiment of worldly human actions, and in reality otherworldly reward and punishment are nothing but the true manifestation of worldly action, and also if the embodiment of actions in the hereafter is among the laws and traditions of the existential world, such justice is classified under existential justice.

Regarding divine justice, questions of this kind are also raised: We all face unpleasant incidents such as disasters, calamities, storms, earthquakes, pains, sufferings, and wars. Are these compatible with divine justice? We face death, which is very painful. Is death compatible with divine justice? Also in human societies, we face oppression and transgression by oppressive humans. Are such actions compatible with divine justice? The answer to these questions will be clarified in the discussions of evils and resurrection.

Chapter Three: The Problem of Evil

The problem of evil has a history as long as human history. From the very first days that humans set foot in the arena of existence and acknowledged with their entire being the Creator of themselves and the world, issues such as diseases, murders, robberies, thefts, and natural events such as volcanoes and earthquakes have been raised for them, and they have weighed the relationship of these issues with the Creator of existence. If God is all-powerful, all-knowing, and absolutely benevolent, why does He not prevent unpleasant occurrences? Why should humans be afflicted by these events?

The problem of evil challenges one of God's three attributes—knowledge, absolute power, and benevolence—because the God of religions is a God who is both all-knowing and absolutely powerful, and also completely benevolent.

A) Definition of Evil

The concepts of good and evil, or goodness and badness, are among self-evident and clear concepts, and all humans understand them to some extent. The existential structure of humans is created in such a way that they understand these concepts. Everyone judges the goodness of justice and the badness of oppression. Sometimes, instead of defining a concept with clearer words and concepts, examples are mentioned as specimens so that the concept becomes clear. We also use this method.

Generally, evil is divided into two types: moral evil and natural evil. Sometimes evil is the result of a human agent, which is called moral evil, such as theft, murder, robbery, and war. At other times, evil occurs without human intervention, which is called natural evil, such as earthquakes, volcanoes, floods, storms, and plagues.

From examining these evils—both natural and moral—it is understood that they are considered evil because they cause human suffering and distress, and if no suffering or distress reaches humans from them, they are not evil. Also, if a person's thinking is such that they do not consider evil matters as causes of their suffering and distress, but rather consider them as factors of development, evil has no meaning or concept.

Therefore, in the discussion of evil, humans place themselves at the center and consider whatever causes them harm and loss to be evil, and whatever aids them in reaching their goal, they consider good and beneficial.

Now that we have become somewhat familiar with the concept of evil, let us refer to the solutions that have been proposed for this problem.

B) Solutions to the Problem of Evil

Religious thinkers have given numerous responses to the problem of evil. Some of these responses are general and encompass all types of evil, and some only answer certain categories of evils. Here we refer to some of these responses.

1. Necessary Consequence of the Material World

This view holds that evil exists in the world, but it is a necessary consequence of the material world, and the material world as a whole is good. Therefore, the creation of the world is better than its non-existence.

Since God is all-powerful, all-knowing, and absolutely benevolent, and His essence is pure good, whatever issues from Him is good. God has created different worlds: a world of angels who are good and have no evil in them. The only evil that can be assumed here is their existential limitation; but they have no conflict or rivalry with each other. However, the material world's necessary consequence, in addition to existential limitation, is conflict and rivalry. It is impossible for the material world to be created without conflict and rivalry. The existence of fire as a whole is good and can be beneficial for human life; but sometimes it also causes harm and creates pain and suffering.

Therefore, the existence of a material world without any conflict and rivalry is contrary to assumption; meaning such a world actually becomes non-material, whereas we have assumed the world to be material. The material world is a world in which conflict and rivalry exist, and evil is its necessary consequence.

Farabi, the great Islamic philosopher, says in this regard:

"God, who is complete in His power, wisdom, and knowledge, all His actions are perfect and without deficiency or fault. The calamities and evils that befall natural things are necessary for the material and natural world. The material world cannot accept pure good."

If someone objects that why did God create the material world with these particular laws, and why did He not establish the laws of nature such that no suffering would result from them; for example, He would have established the law of burning in such a way that it would not burn the hands and clothes of the innocent. It is actually a mistake to use the terminology of means and ends for the all-powerful God, because the all-powerful can create the end directly and without using means. Only beings who are not all-powerful use means to reach ends.

These objections return to this issue: why is conflict and rivalry a necessary consequence of the material world, and why doesn't the material world, while being material, have non-material characteristics? Islamic thinkers have introduced a discussion here that power does not relate to essential impossibilities, and this non-relation is not due to the Creator's inability; rather, it is due to the object of power, which has no possibility of realization.

This objection, which Western critics have recently raised, had been raised by Muslim thinkers before them and they responded to it. Ibn Sina, in the book *Metaphysics of the Shifa*, says regarding the evil of the world:

If it is said that why did God not prevent evil in the world so that a world that is pure good would be realized, in response it must be said: If the material world, which has unavoidable association with evils, were created in such a way that no evil would be realized in it, it would no longer be material; it would be another world that is pure good, whereas such a world has already been created by God.

Mulla Sadra also raises this objection in the book *Asfar* and then attempts to answer it.

Therefore, it is impossible for the laws of the material world to be otherwise. If it were otherwise, our world would no longer be the material world, and since the Wise, All-Knowing, All-Powerful, and absolutely benevolent God, if the creation of such a material world were possible, would have created it, and since He has not created it, its existence was not possible.

But in answer to the question of whether it would not have been better if God, due to the few evils of this world, had refrained from creating the material world, it can be said that abandoning the abundant good of the material world due to the existence of few evils is incompatible with divine grace, because abandoning abundant good due to little evil is itself considered abundant evil. Is it right to refrain from creating fire due to the little evil it might entail? If fire is not created, countless goods that come from it will be lost.

2. Resulting from Human Freedom

God has granted humans the blessing of freedom and free will and has also inspired them with goods and evils. Also, happiness-bringing instructions have been given to humans for their development through messengers. Humans can, through free will, traverse the path of development, which is following conscience and divine prophets, and they can disobey and not turn to conscience and divine instructions. Some humans, through their own free will, commit evil actions whose necessary consequence is the suffering and torment of others. Therefore, evil in the world results from human wickedness, and human wickedness results from their freedom and free will.

If humans adopt proper behavior and conduct, they can remove many natural evils from their path; for example, with God-given reason, they can build sturdy houses against earthquakes and remain safe from earthquakes. Many human sins bring natural evils in their wake, and humans, by avoiding sins, can be freed from many hardships and calamities. God says in the Qur'an:

"And if only the people of the cities had believed and feared God, We would have opened upon them blessings from the heaven and the earth; but they denied [the messengers], so We seized them for what they were earning." (Qur'an 7:96)

The implication of this verse is that if humans do not believe and do not adopt piety, divine blessings from earth and heaven will be cut off, and they will fall into hardship. It also says:

"Corruption has appeared throughout the land and sea by [reason of] what the hands of people have earned so He may let them taste part of [the consequence of] what they have done that perhaps they will return [to righteousness]." (Qur'an 30:41)

"And We would not punish until We sent a messenger." (Qur'an 17:15)

Meaning, it is impossible for God to punish those for whom He has not completed the proof. In other words, divine punishment, which can also be natural punishment, includes those who rise in opposition to the divine messenger and undertake improper actions. Thus, divine punishment is rooted in ugly and improper human actions.

As mentioned, from the verses of the Qur'an it becomes clear that many natural evils and calamities result from human sins, and therefore Hospers' objection that "this solution only justifies moral evils" is incorrect. But regarding the pain and suffering that reaches from one person to another as a result of the actions of one individual, it can be said:

- Many of the pains and sufferings that reach people from oppressors are the result of the people's own actions. If they unite and rise against the oppressor, there will no longer be oppression and pain and suffering. God says in this regard:

"Indeed, God will not change the condition of a people until they change what is in themselves." (Qur'an 13:11)

Therefore, creating humans as free and having free will is better than creating compelled humans, even though freedom and free will are sometimes abused.

3. Resulting from Partial View

Some thinkers believe that the reason humans consider many things to be evil is rooted in superficial, partial, narrow-minded, and hasty judgments. If they had broader and more comprehensive awareness, they would never judge some matters to be evil. God, from His infinite knowledge and wisdom, has created the best possible world, in which everything is in its proper place; but humans, who possess limited knowledge, cannot judge the world correctly. For example, someone who only sees the septic tank of a building and is unaware of its other parts will not have a correct judgment about it. But if they have a comprehensive and complete insight into the building, they will see that the existence of the tank is not only not bad, but is very necessary for the building.

The noble Qur'an considers the reason for disliking some matters to result from lack of comprehensive and complete knowledge and says:

"But perhaps you hate a thing and it is good for you; and perhaps you love a thing and it is bad for you. And God Knows, while you know not." (Qur'an 2:216)

"But perhaps you hate a thing and God makes therein much good." (Qur'an 4:19)

C) Benefits of Evils in the World

So far we have referred to some of the mysteries of the existence of evils in the world, and here we will explain them in list form. The question is: why is the world created in such a way that it has evil and deficiency? What is the benefit of these evils?

1. Flourishing of Potentials

The human structure is such that many of their abilities and potentials flourish in facing hardships and difficulties. Many inventions and innovations result from encountering problems and hardships. Therefore, the existence of evil is beneficial for human spiritual, psychological, and intellectual development. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"For indeed, with hardship [will be] ease. Indeed, with hardship [will be] ease." (Qur'an 94:5-6)

Imam Ali (peace be upon him) says in this regard:

"Know that the branch of a tree that grows in the wasteland is harder, and the bark of beautiful greenery is softer, and the fire of desert plants burns more intensely, and their extinguishing is slower."

Thus, hardship and difficulties are causes of perseverance, steadfastness, and ease, and in other words, the existence of evils and ugliness is necessary for the emergence of the beautiful collection of the world. Even beauties take their manifestation from ugliness. If there were no ugliness and evil, beauty and goodness would have no meaning.

2. Awakening from Heedlessness

Among the benefits of evils and hardships is that they awaken humans from the sleep of heedlessness. Consider a driver who, due to heedlessness, pays no attention to traffic laws and regulations. If they remain heedless, they will cause the destruction of themselves and others. When the police, as a warning, fine them and prevent them from continuing their route, this hardship and inconvenience is to their benefit and causes their awakening and alertness so that they avoid unpleasant consequences.

God also in the noble Qur'an mentions hardships and problems as factors for awakening from heedlessness:

"And we will surely let them taste the nearer punishment short of the greater punishment that perhaps they will repent." (Qur'an 32:21)

Therefore, evil is a factor for taking lessons so that perhaps they may take heed and be guided to the straight path.

3. Divine Test

Sometimes God tests His servants with calamity and hardship to distinguish true believers, just as humans purify impure gold with heat and give it more beauty and value. Likewise, God tests some servants in the crucible of suffering, calamity, and difficulties so that they become pure and more valuable. The noble Qur'an states:

"Do the people think that they will be left to say, 'We believe' and they will not be tried? But We have certainly tried those before them, and God will surely make evident those who are truthful, and He will surely make evident the liars." (Qur'an 29:2-3)

Of course, other benefits can also be enumerated for evil, but we do not have the opportunity for that.

Chapter Four: Monotheism and Worship

A) Levels of Monotheism

From the Qur'an's perspective, monotheism and polytheism play the primary role in human life, because human actions and behavior are manifestations of one's beliefs and thoughts. If one's thought becomes monotheistic, their actions will also take on a monotheistic character, and if polytheism finds its way into one's thought and heart, it will be reflected in their actions as well.

The levels of monotheism are:

1. Monotheism in essence
2. Monotheism in attributes
3. Monotheism in creation
4. Monotheism in lordship
5. Monotheism in legislation
6. Monotheism in obedience
7. Monotheism in sovereignty
8. Monotheism in worship

1. Monotheism in Essence (Tawhid al-Dhat)

Monotheism in essence means that God is unique, incomparable, and without equal. In clearer terms, God's essence is such that it does not accept multiplicity or plurality, and one cannot imagine another individual for Him in the external world or in the mind.

The Qur'an and narrations clearly point to God's uniqueness, His being without equal, and the indivisibility of His sacred essence. Among the verses of the noble Qur'an in this regard are:

"God bears witness that there is no deity except Him, and [so do] the angels and those of knowledge - [that He is] maintaining [creation] in justice. There is no deity except Him, the Exalted in Might, the Wise." (Qur'an 3:18)

In this verse, angels and scholars clearly testify to monotheism. In another verse it states:

"Say, 'He is God, [who is] One, God, the Eternal Refuge. He neither begets nor is born, nor is there to Him any equivalent.'" (Qur'an 112:1-4)

Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says in this regard:

"He is One, having no likeness among things."

"Indeed, He, the Mighty and Majestic, is One in meaning; He is not divisible in existence, imagination, or intellect."

From these verses and narrations, it becomes clear that God is unique and incomparable, and His essence is also simple and without parts.

Reason also indicates that God is unique and incomparable, and His essence is simple and indivisible.

An unlimited being does not accept multiplicity. If we consider an unlimited being to be multiple, to preserve duality, we must necessarily consider each one as finite from some aspect or aspects, so that we can say this is other than that. Because if two things are identical from every aspect, they certainly will not be two beings. Therefore, an unlimited and infinite being does not accept multiplicity, because if it accepts multiplicity, it will not be infinite.

In other words, the requirement of otherness and duality is that the existence of each one is outside the existence of the other, and where the first one is, there is no trace of the second, and vice versa. This is finitude and limitation itself, while God is unlimited and infinite, and consequently is not dual.

To clarify this point, consider this example: if a body becomes infinitely large in all its dimensions, another body that is also infinite in all its dimensions cannot be conceived, because the first body has filled all space and place, leaving no place for another body. With this assumption, if you suppose a second body, that body will either definitely be identical to the first one, or the first body is finite and limited from some aspect or aspects.

2. Monotheism in Attributes (Tawhid al-Sifat)

God possesses all perfect attributes, and reason and revelation indicate the existence of these perfections in God's essence. Therefore, God is All-Knowing, All-Powerful, Living, All-Hearing, All-Seeing, etc. These attributes differ from one another in terms of concept. What we understand from "All-Knowing" is different from what we understand from "All-Powerful." But do these attributes, just as they differ in concept, also have differences in external existence, meaning in God's existence, or is there one essence that is both All-Knowing and All-Powerful?

The answer is: Since their difference in God's essence is associated with multiplicity and composition in the divine essence, the aforementioned attributes, despite their conceptual difference, have unity in terms of reality. In other words, God's essence,

despite its simplicity, possesses all these perfections, and it is not the case that one part of God's essence is knowledge, another part is power, and a third part is life. God's essence is entirely knowledge, entirely power, entirely life, etc.

For further clarity, consider this example: Each of us is known by God and at the same time His creation. It is true that the concept of "known" is different from the concept of "created," but in terms of application, our entire existence is known by God and also His creation, not that part of our essence is known by God and another part is His creation. Therefore, in terms of instance, each one is identical to the other, and collectively they are identical to our essence.

Thus, God's essential attributes, while being eternal and everlasting, are identical to His essence. Therefore, the belief of those who consider God's attributes eternal and everlasting but additional to His essence is incorrect, because this view actually originates from comparing God's attributes to human attributes, and since human attributes are additional to their essence, it has been imagined that this is also the case with God; whereas God is not similar to anything. Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) says in this regard:

"God has been and is our Lord from eternity, and knowledge is identical to His essence, not that there is something known; and hearing is identical to His essence, not that there is something heard; and sight is His essence, not that there is something seen; and power is His essence, not that there is something over which power is exercised."

3. Monotheism in Creation (Tawhid fi al-Khaliqiyya)

Monotheism in creation means that in the world, there is no creator other than God, and every being that has worn the garment of existence is His creation and creature.

The Qur'an and human reason testify to this monotheism. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"Say, 'God is the Creator of all things, and He is the One, the Prevailing.'" (Qur'an 13:16)

"That is God, your Lord, Creator of all things; there is no deity except Him." (Qur'an 40:62)

From these verses it becomes clear that God is the creator of everything that wears the garment of existence. Also, in addition to revelation, reason testifies to monotheism in creation, because God is the Necessary Being, and all things other than God are contingent and needy, and consequently their existence is from God.

Of course, monotheism in creation does not mean denying the principle of causality in the system of existence, because the existence of cause and the causality of things are among the manifestations of God's will. It is God who has granted warmth and brightness to the sun and moon, and whenever He wishes, He takes this characteristic from them. Therefore, the Creator is unique and incomparable.

The Qur'an also confirms the system of causality in the world:

"It is God who sends the winds, and they stir the clouds and spread them in the sky however He wills..." (Qur'an 30:48)

4. Monotheism in Lordship (Tawhid fi al-Rububiyya)

Monotheism in lordship means that only God is effective in the management, administration, and governance of the world and humanity. Monotheism in lordship has two manifestations: existential management and legislative management. We will discuss legislative management under a separate heading. Now we will explain monotheism in the realm of existential management:

The meaning of existential management is the governance of the world of creation, meaning that the administration of the universe, like its creation and origination, is the act of the One God. In human affairs, management is separable from origination; for example, one person builds a factory and another manages it; but in the world of creation, the Creator and Governor are one, and the point is that the management of the world is not separate from creatorship.

The history of the prophets shows that the issue of monotheism in creation was not disputed by their communities, and if there was any polytheism, it was mostly related to the management and governance of the world. For example, the polytheists of the era of Prophet Abraham (peace be upon him) believed in only one Creator, but they mistakenly thought that the star, moon, or sun was the manager of the world, and Abraham's debate with them was about this very matter.

From the verses of the Qur'an, it is understood that the polytheists of the prophetic era also considered part of their destiny to be in the hands of their deities. The Qur'an says:

"And they have taken besides God [false] deities that they might be for them honor." (Qur'an 19:81)

"And they have taken besides God [false] deities that perhaps they would be helped. They are not able to help them, and they [themselves] are for them soldiers in attendance." (Qur'an 36:74-75)

The Qur'an in numerous verses warns polytheists that they worship things that are unable to bring benefit or harm to themselves or their worshippers. This set of verses indicates that the polytheists of the Prophet's era believed in the benefit and harm-bringing of their deities, and this was their motivation for worshipping idols.

In some verses, the Qur'an reproaches polytheists for supposing equals for God in the matter of management or attributing divine functions to them. The polytheists considered idols effective in victory, protection from danger in travel, and the like, and even considered intercession as their right, believing that idols had the right to intercede without God's permission. In some cases, they considered the worship of idols as a means of nearness to God. The Qur'an quotes polytheists on the Day of Resurrection reproaching themselves and their idols, saying:

"By God, we were indeed in manifest error when we equated you with the Lord of the worlds."

However, the polytheists contemporary with the Prophet of Islam (peace be upon him) were monotheists in some matters such as giving sustenance, giving life and causing death, and the general management of the world. The Qur'an says:

"Say, 'Who provides for you from the heaven and the earth? Or who controls hearing and sight? And who brings the living out of the dead and brings the dead out of the living? And who arranges [every] matter?' They will say, 'God.' So say, 'Then will you not fear Him?'" (Qur'an 10:31)

But monotheism in lordship means drawing a line of nullification over any thought of independent management without divine permission for other than God, and the proof of monotheistic lordship is clear, because regarding the world and humanity, the governance of the system of creation is not separate from its creation, and if the Creator of the world and humanity is one, their Manager is also one and no more. It is due to this clear connection between creation and the management of the world that God Almighty in the Qur'an, where He speaks of the creation of the heavens, calls Himself the Manager of the world and says:

"It is God who erected the heavens without pillars that you [can] see; then He established Himself above the Throne and made subject the sun and the moon, each running [its course] for a specified term. He arranges [each] matter; He details the signs that you may, of the meeting with your Lord, be certain." (Qur'an 13:2)

In another verse, the Qur'an considers the harmony of the creation system as proof of the oneness of the world's Manager:

"Had there been within the heavens and earth gods besides God, they both would have been ruined." (Qur'an 21:22)

Of course, monotheism in management is not incompatible with belief in other managers who perform their duties with God's permission.

5. Monotheism in Legislation (Tawhid fi al-Tashri')

Monotheism in legislation and lawmaking means that legislation and lawmaking is exclusively for God, because the one who can take the reins of the affairs of God's servants' lives is none other than God. Humanity seeks social life, and every society needs law. The legislator must have two characteristics:

1. **Be a knower of humanity:** meaning to be precisely aware of all the secrets and mysteries of the physical and psychological aspects of humanity. A doctor's prescription is accurate and complete only if they are fully aware of the patient's conditions and prescribe according to the patient's temperament and psychological conditions. There is no more complete knowledge of humanity than God's, because no one knows humanity better than its maker and creator.
2. **Be free from any self-interest:** because legislators may enact laws under the influence of personal, group, tribal, and partisan interests. It is God who is free from this characteristic, because He has no interest in society and is free from the sense of self-interest.

Of course, some of the rulings of the Qur'an need explanation, which is the duty of the Prophet and the Pure Imams, and they have also assigned the mission of explanation to scholars and true Islamic scholars. Jurists and scholars also discover and then explain divine laws and rulings.

6. Monotheism in Obedience (Tawhid fi al-Ta'a)

Monotheism in obedience means that only God should be obeyed; humans should listen to His word and act upon it. The universe, including humanity and all its capabilities, are dependent on God and belong to Him, and therefore, only He is worthy of obedience. This is why the Qur'an recommends only obedience to God:

"So fear God as much as you are able and listen and obey and spend [in the way of God]; it is better for your selves." (Qur'an 64:16)

Also, obedience to the Prophet is obedience to God:

"He who obeys the Messenger has obeyed God." (Qur'an 4:80)

But what is meant by obedience to the Prophet? One of the Prophet's duties is to convey God's message, which is done in two ways:

1. Receiving and conveying divine verses that are revealed to the Prophet's heart
2. Explaining divine verses, which are manifested in the form of hadiths

The Prophet, apart from the position of conveying and explaining revelation, has other positions including leadership, and for the reform and administration of Islamic society, he issues commands and prohibitions, gives orders for jihad, declares general mobilization, and these orders must also be obeyed.

Also, the Qur'an commands to obey those in authority (ulu al-amr) and also parents. The clear examples of those in authority are the Pure Imams (peace be upon them), then true Islamic scholars, jurists, and scholars. Following parents is conditional upon there being no disobedience to God in it. Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says:

"The right of parents over their child is that the child obeys them in everything except in disobedience to God."

Obedience to the officials of the Islamic system and legitimate governors is also obedience to those in authority, and obedience to those in authority is obedience to the Messenger, and obedience to the Messenger is obedience to God.

7. Monotheism in Sovereignty (Tawhid fi al-Hakimiyya)

The meaning of monotheism in sovereignty is that the right to rule essentially belongs to God, and the rule of others must be with His specific or general permission. The rule of prophets and divine guardians are all with God's permission. Humans have never been without government in any period, and essentially society is based on two pillars: one is law, and the other is the executors of law. In Islam, government is not a goal; rather, because implementing rulings and laws and ensuring its lofty goals is not possible without political organization and structure and an executor, the need for government and ruler arises, just as the Prophet (peace be upon him) personally established a state and government. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"Legislation is not but for God. He has commanded that you worship not except Him." (Qur'an 12:40)

From this verse, it becomes clear that sovereignty belongs only to God.

"And whoever does not judge by what God has revealed - then it is those who are the disbelievers." (Qur'an 5:44)

"And whoever does not judge by what God has revealed - then it is those who are the wrongdoers." (Qur'an 5:45)

8. Monotheism in Worship (Tawhid fi al-'Ibada)

Monotheism is the foundation of the call of all divine prophets throughout history. All humans should worship the One God and abstain from worshipping other beings. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And We certainly sent into every nation a messenger, [saying], 'Worship God and avoid Taghut.'" (Qur'an 16:36)

"Say, 'O People of the Scripture, come to a word that is equitable between us and you - that we will not worship except God and not associate anything with Him.'" (Qur'an 3:64)

In this verse, the noble Qur'an considers monotheism as the common principle among all heavenly religions.

B) The Secrets of Prayer

At the end of discussions related to monotheism in worship, it is appropriate to also speak about prayer and the best manifestation of practical monotheism. Prayer is the best manifestation of worshipping God; it is a means that can give expression to servitude to God. Prayer is the ultimate purpose of human creation. None of the acts of worship have such capacity as prayer. Prayer is a comprehensive worship that can place the entire existence of a person - including physical and apparent aspects as well as mental, spiritual, and inner aspects - in the service of God, and for this reason, after knowledge of God, it is considered the best deed.

If we look at the Qur'an - the only authentic heavenly book that has remained free from distortion - we will see that it has not given importance to any deed like prayer. Based on Qur'anic verses, this deed was also obligatory in previous religions, and all prophets emphasized it. In a verse, the Qur'an quotes Prophet Abraham (peace be upon him) as saying:

"My Lord, make me an establisher of prayer, and [many] from my descendants. Our Lord, and accept my supplication." (Qur'an 14:40)

And in another verse, again quoting Prophet Abraham (peace be upon him), it says:

"Our Lord, I have settled some of my descendants in an uncultivated valley near Your sacred House, our Lord, that they may establish prayer." (Qur'an 14:37)

This verse shows that during the era of Prophet Abraham (peace be upon him), prayer was an obligation, and the purpose of building the Ka'bah was also this. In the first revelation to Prophet Moses (peace be upon him), prayer is mentioned:

"Indeed, I am God. There is no deity except Me, so worship Me and establish prayer for My remembrance." (Qur'an 20:14)

Prophet Jesus (peace be upon him), while still in the cradle, spoke of prayer:

"And [made me] blessed wherever I am and has enjoined upon me prayer and zakah as long as I remain alive." (Qur'an 19:31)

And also among the recommendations of Luqman to his son was prayer:

"O my son, establish prayer." (Qur'an 31:17)

The noble Prophet of Islam (peace be upon him) was also addressed in this way:

"Recite what has been revealed to you of the Book and establish prayer. Indeed, prayer prohibits immorality and wrongdoing, and the remembrance of God is greater." (Qur'an 29:45)

Islamic narrations have also emphasized prayer. Imam Baqir (peace be upon him) says:

"Prayer is the pillar of religion."

"Pillar" (amud) means the support of a tent and is placed in its middle. If the pillar is removed, the tent is no longer standing and will fall to the ground.

And again in narrations, we read that the first question from servants on the Day of Judgment is about prayer. If the prayer is accepted, other deeds are also accepted, and if their prayer is not accepted, other deeds will not be accepted either.

Prayer has numerous secrets and wisdoms. The worship of prayer is endowed with many secrets of human-making. Humans do not have the ability to comprehend all the secrets of prayer, but to the extent of their capacity, they can understand some of them, the most important of which are:

1. Remembrance of God

The Qur'an considers one of the secrets of prayer to be the remembrance of God and says:

"Establish prayer for My remembrance." (Qur'an 20:14)

The remembrance of God gives peace to hearts, is life-giving, is a factor in the development of many virtues, and also promotes justice, spreads truth and reality, and prevents transgression against individual and social rights.

Much of what the Western world today, with police and government apparatus, is trying to imperfectly implement can be spontaneously realized through prayer and the peace of hearts, and the person who prays develops automatically.

2. Unity

Prayer at specified times is a manifestation of the unity and oneness of the great Islamic nation. All Muslims stand at specific times facing the qiblah, worshipping the Lord of the universe with certain formalities. This itself is a great manifestation of unity that connects and unites Muslims through the bond of worship and connection with God.

Today, Friday prayers in Islamic countries and congregational prayers in mosques are among the greatest manifestations of the unity of the Islamic nation.

3. Eliminating Class Distinctions

Prayer is a factor in eliminating class distinctions that arise in materialistic societies. When Muslims stand for prayer, there is no difference between officials and ordinary people, rich and poor. All classes are obligated to perform this obligation at specific hours, and when prayer is performed in congregation, it takes on an even clearer manifestation, and the face of equality and equality becomes visible from the compressed rows of worshippers. People from all classes and strata stand side by side without discrimination to raise the call of servitude and worship with their entire being. Those who give value to the etiquette of servitude to God in unison feel with their entire being that position, wealth, health, and outstanding talents are God's gift that has been entrusted to them for testing servitude, and are not a cause for boasting and class discrimination.

4. Avoiding Sin

A worshipper must, for the validity and acceptance of their prayer, abstain from sins. The place and clothing for prayer must be from lawful means, and the worshipper is obliged to provide the water for ablution and ritual bath from lawful property. Such obligations cause them to be careful in their work and livelihood, to engage in work and business according to Islamic standards. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"Indeed, prayer prohibits immorality and wrongdoing." (Qur'an 29:45)

Prayer is practice for staying away from sin and strengthening the spirit of faith and attention to God. This attention has degrees, and for those who have no fear of committing sins, the remembrance of God is only the ground for piety. In other words, the Qur'an's meaning that prayer is a cause of staying away from sin is not that every worshipper is immune to all sins; rather, the meaning is that prayer causes remembrance of God and attention to the divine position, and the natural effect of such attention is that in a person, the ground for obedience and abandonment of sin is created. Nevertheless, due to weak attention to God, stronger factors may neutralize its effect.

In any case, true and complete prayer is a deterrent factor from sin and disobedience. Narrations in this regard have been narrated from the noble Prophet of Islam (peace be upon him), among them is:

Regarding a man who prayed with him but committed ugly deeds at the same time, he said: *"His prayer will one day keep him from ugly deeds."* Not long after, the man repented.

And regarding a man who prayed during the day and stole at night, he said: *"His prayer will keep him from this deed."*

In summary, as mentioned, if prayer is true prayer, it affects the sinful person, and sometimes this effect is very noticeable and sometimes slight. The more sincere and complete the prayer, the stronger its educational and deterrent effect from sins. Prayer can prevent theft, immorality, and wrongdoing.

5. Obedience

Prayer strengthens the sense of obedience and submission to absolute perfection. Submission to perfections and absolute perfection is one of the human virtues that, like other human virtues, needs practice and exercise. Prayer is practice for this feeling so that humans submit before every perfection, especially absolute perfection. Prayer makes humans submit before God and divine guardians. Prayer makes humans rebellious before idols and tyrants, so much so that prayer and avoidance of taghut are two sides of the same coin.

6. Physical Health

The worshipper must wash their entire body at specific times or perform ablution most of the time, and observe the cleanliness of the body and places of ablution in every respect. If they observe the recommended acts of ablution, such as rinsing the mouth

and nose, and cleanliness of clothing and place of prostration, etc., they have provided the means of health and cleanliness of the body.

Prayer, in addition to mental health, is also a source of physical and bodily health, and the worshipper's person and clothing must be free from impurity and pollution.

7. Sincerity

A condition for the acceptance of prayer is that the worshipper has sincerity in performing this duty and is far from base material motives, such as attracting others' attention or material benefit (showing off) or out of mere habit. The meaning of sincerity is that the motivation for worship and worshipping God is only fulfilling divine obligations, or higher than that, the worthiness of His essence for worship.

The element of sincerity in humans causes the cultivation of the spirit of servitude as a transcendent quality and this spirit is the origin of many moral virtues. A society where ethics rules and work is done for God and ensuring the interests of society pays attention to the depth of work more than its appearance, and instead of dealing with appearances, thinks about the future and its valuable results.

8. Vitality and Enthusiasm

When a worshipper stands for prayer, they should pray with enthusiasm. If they perform this act with laziness, it will not be pleasing to God. Therefore, although prayer is performed for nearness to God and His servitude, one of its conditions is enthusiasm and vitality, and whoever avoids laziness and inertia in the five daily prayers, avoidance of laziness becomes their way of life. The Qur'an reproaches hypocrites for standing for prayer with laziness and says:

"And when they stand for prayer, they stand lazily." (Qur'an 4:142)

9. Time Management

One who stands for prayer at five specific times and strives to pray at the beginning of the time usually follows a precise order in other tasks as well. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"Indeed, prayer has been decreed upon the believers at specific times." (Qur'an 4:103)

"So woe to those who pray, who are heedless of their prayer." (Qur'an 107:4-5)

Commander of the Faithful (peace be upon him) says in his letter to Muhammad ibn Abi Bakr:

"Be watchful of prayer time and pray it on time. Do not pray it before its time because you are idle, and do not delay it from its time because you are busy."

C) The Reason for Human Worship

Sometimes it is asked: Why should humans worship God? What need does God have for our worship?

The answer to this question can be stated in two ways:

1. **If the purpose of worship is to fulfill God's needs** and for Him to benefit from our worship, the question arises that God's existence is unlimited and infinite and free from any deficiency and need. What need does He have for our worship? But if the purpose of worshipping Him is our own development, worship is considered a means of our development and happiness, and His command to worship is grace, mercy, and guidance that leads us to deserved perfection.
2. **Worship and supplication and any work done for God's pleasure** has precious individual and social effects and is among high educational and moral values, because:

First, worshipping God enlivens the sense of appreciation and gratitude in humans. Being grateful to the position that has placed great and valuable blessings at human disposal is a sign of the worthiness and deservingness of the grateful person for the favors that have been done to them. Thanking and being grateful to God has this result: that the grateful person, by thanking and fulfilling duty, manifests their servitude to the goodness they have received.

Second, worship and worshipping God is a cause of human spiritual development. What development is higher than our soul and spirit being connected with absolute perfection and seeking help from His infinite power and unlimited force in the duties of servitude and performing life's tasks, and becoming worthy and deserving to the extent that they can speak with Him?

Moreover, worship is the philosophy of human and jinn creation. Through prayer and worship, humans approach the human horizon, which is servitude to God.

Prayer is the methodology of life and the method of harmony with creation. Prayer is a sign of human freedom from gold, force, and deceit. Prayer is a sign of human will and maturity. A student who prays is an intellectual who has found the way of intellectuality and has obtained the method of educational science and research in the path of perfection toward God.

Part Three: Resurrection (Ma'ad)

Chapter One: General Matters

A) Definition and Importance of Resurrection

1. Definition

"Ma'ad" (resurrection) linguistically means returning and comes from the root ('awd). In technical terminology, it means coming back to life after death. Resurrection means the renewed life of humans and other beings. God is capable of creating the living from the dead and the dead from the living.

2. Importance

Among the very important and destiny-determining subjects for humans is resurrection. Humans are interested in investigating resurrection for two reasons:

1. Humans are inherently knowledge-loving and truth-seeking, especially about matters related to their life, and resurrection is one of such subjects. Humans want to know whether their life ends with death or they will have life after it. What is the quality of transition from this life to that life? Is the life of that world multi-staged? Should the necessities and means needed for that world be prepared there, or is the life of this world the prerequisite and foundation for the pleasures and displeasures of that world? In other words, is this world the farm of the hereafter? The answer to these questions can somewhat quench humanity's thirst for truth-seeking.

2. Knowing the ultimate purpose and goal of life is of great importance to humans because it plays an important role in shaping human activities and actions.

A person who considers death as the end of their life will organize their behavior in such a way as to obtain maximum pleasure in this world by any possible means and only meet the needs and wants of their worldly life. But one who believes in eternal life will organize their worldly life plan in such a way that it is as beneficial as possible for their eternal life, and on the other hand, the hardships and failures of worldly life do not discourage or dishearten them, and they constantly strive in the path of acquiring eternal happiness and perfection.

3. The Qur'an's View

After monotheism, an important subject that the Qur'an gives special attention to is resurrection. The number of Qur'anic verses about the world after death exceeds 1,400 verses, and this number of verses indicates the importance of resurrection in the Qur'an. Resurrection has also been a concern of all divine prophets. Essentially, the call to religion is meaningful only if life after death is among its fundamental principles.

Now let us refer to some Qur'anic verses in this regard:

"Then did you think that We created you uselessly and that to Us you would not be returned?" (Qur'an 23:115)

"Does man think that We will not assemble his bones? Yes. [We are] Able [even] to proportion his fingertips. But man desires to continue in sin. He asks, 'When is the Day of Resurrection?'" (Qur'an 75:3-5)

This verse indicates that the reason for denying resurrection is that humans want the path to be open for their sinning, because if one believes in resurrection, they are constantly watchful of their behavior and conduct and do not sin or disobey.

God, at the time of Adam's descent to earth, said:

"[God] said, 'Descend, being to one another enemies. And for you on the earth is a place of settlement and enjoyment for a time.' He said, 'Therein you will live, and therein you will die, and from it you will be brought forth.'" (Qur'an 7:24-25)

Therefore, according to Qur'anic verses, Prophet Noah (peace be upon him), while fighting against polytheism and idol worship, explicitly presented the idea of resurrection and asked his people to seek God's forgiveness. The Qur'an narrates Noah's words as follows:

"And God has caused you to grow from the earth a [progressive] growth. Then He will return you into it and extract you [another] extraction." (Qur'an 71:17-18)

The discussion of resurrection in the current Torah is very sparse, and perhaps the inner inclination of the Jewish people toward worldly life has caused them to delete the verses of resurrection from the Torah; but the Qur'an narrates the issue of resurrection from the tongue of Prophet Moses (peace be upon him) with full emphasis:

"And Moses said, 'Indeed, I have sought refuge in my Lord and your Lord from every arrogant one who does not believe in the Day of Account.'" (Qur'an 40:27)

According to Qur'anic verses, Prophet Jesus (peace be upon him) mentioned resurrection on the very day he was born and said:

"And peace is on me the day I was born and the day I will die and the day I am raised alive." (Qur'an 19:33)

Thus, from all these verses it appears that in the Qur'anic view, belief in resurrection is one of the fundamental principles of the teachings of divine prophets, and this can also be a scriptural proof for the existence of resurrection.

B) Similar Examples

God in the Qur'an refers to examples similar to resurrection to make it clear that God has the power to bring humans back to life, just as their first creation was also by God's hand. Or these examples are witnesses so that humans can tangibly see the phenomenon of resurrection to gain inner certainty, even though they have reached it through reasoning and reflection, or these examples themselves are the best proof for the occurrence of resurrection.

1. Reviving Birds

Islamic commentators narrate that Abraham (peace be upon him) was passing by a sea. He saw a man lying by the sea, part of his body in the water and another part outside, and sea and land animals were attacking from both sides, eating him, and the parts of his body were scattered. Seeing this scene made him contemplate resurrection—how will he be brought back to life? He asked God to show him how the dead are brought back to life after their parts have been scattered. There is no doubt that Prophet Abraham (peace be upon him) was aware of resurrection through reason and revelation and believed in it; but for greater certainty and inner peace, he made such a request. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And [mention] when Abraham said, 'My Lord, show me how You give life to the dead.' [God] said, 'Have you not believed?' He said, 'Yes, but [I ask] only that my heart may be satisfied.' [God] said, 'Take four birds and commit them to yourself. Then [after slaughtering them] put on each hill a portion of them; then call them - they will come [flying] to you in haste. And know that God is Exalted in Might and Wise.'" (Qur'an 2:260)

These four birds were: peacock, dove, rooster, and crow. From this verse it becomes clear that God, on the Day of Resurrection, is capable of bringing humans back to life after their bodies have been scattered, just as He has the power to do this work in this world as well.

2. The Revival of Uzair

Uzair, or according to some narrations Jeremiah, who was one of the prophets of the Children of Israel, when traveling while mounted on a beast and carrying some food and drink, passed by a settlement whose walls had collapsed on its roofs, and the corpses and decayed bones of its inhabitants were visible. When he saw this horrifying scene, he said: How will God bring these dead back to life?!

God, to remove his amazement, took his soul and brought him back to life a hundred years later, and asked him: How long have you been in this desert? He thought he had lingered there only a short time. He immediately replied in answer: One day or less!

He was addressed: You have been here for a hundred years. Now look at your food and drink and see how during this period, by God's command, no change has occurred in them; but so that you know a hundred years have passed since your death, look at your mount and see that it has been scattered and dispersed, and death has scattered it. Then look and see how We gather its scattered parts and bring it to life. At this time, Uzair said: "I know that God is capable of all things."

3. The People of the Cave

A ruler named Decius ruled over Rome in the years 249-251 BC. When his glory, majesty, and tyranny increased, with complete rebellion, he claimed lordship and called the leaders of the people to obey him. Whoever accepted his divinity, he gave them abundant wealth, and whoever did not follow him, he killed.

A group of pure young men, to escape from the tyrannical ruler, left the city under the pretext of hunting and had a dog with them. They reached a cave and took refuge in it. Divine will decreed that they sleep in the cave for 309 years. After waking, they thought they had not lingered more than a day or half a day.

It was arranged that one of them would go to the city to get food. After entering the city, he found everything changed. People's appearance and the city's conditions had completely transformed. Something happened to him and they took him to the king, and ultimately they understood that he was one of those who had disappeared several hundred years ago, because the incident of their disappearance had been narrated orally and occasionally recorded in history books.

The city's people, by witnessing this incident, learned a great lesson about resurrection, because they understood that bringing the dead back to life on the Day of Resurrection is an easy matter. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And similarly, We caused them to be found that they [who found them] would know that the promise of God is truth and that of the Hour there is no doubt." (Qur'an 18:21)

4. Bringing the Dead Back to Life

Qur'anic verses clearly indicate that Prophet Jesus (peace be upon him), by God's permission, brought the dead back to life and healed the blind. The Qur'an says:

"[The time] when God will say, 'O Jesus, Son of Mary, remember My favor upon you and upon your mother when I supported you with the Pure Spirit and you spoke to the people in the cradle and in maturity; and [remember] when I taught you writing and wisdom and the Torah and the Gospel; and when you designed from clay [what was] like the form of a bird with My permission, then you breathed into it, and it became a bird with My permission; and you healed the blind and the leper with My permission; and when you brought forth the dead with My permission..." (Qur'an 5:110)

This verse indicates that in this very world, humans can be brought back to life, in addition to the fact that in the hereafter, God is also capable of bringing humans back to life.

5. Plant Growth

The growth of plants after dryness and death is like the revival of humans after death. Contemplation of this phenomenon, which constantly occurs before human eyes, is sufficient for them to realize the possibility of their own life after death; but many are heedless of this ordinary and familiar phenomenon. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"So observe the effects of the mercy of God - how He gives life to the earth after its lifelessness. Indeed, that [same one] will give life to the dead, and He is over all things competent." (Qur'an 30:50)

"And you see the earth barren, but when We send down upon it rain, it quivers and swells and grows [something] of every beautiful kind. That is because God is the Truth and because He gives life to the dead and because He is over all things competent." (Qur'an 22:5-6)

For those who believe in the authority of the Qur'an and consider it the eternal miracle, these examples similar to resurrection clearly indicate that resurrection is a possible and feasible matter, and God is capable of doing it.

C) Proofs for Resurrection

Most discussions about resurrection should be taken from the teachings of revelation; but reason can also prove some generalities about resurrection, including the existence of resurrection, although these same rational proofs can also be recreated in the form of scriptural proofs. Now let us refer to some of them:

1. The Proof of Innate Nature (Fitrah)

Innate nature means the type of creation; meaning humans are created in such a way that they have a desire for eternal life and survival, and are averse to non-existence and annihilation. The world does not have the worthiness of eternity. Therefore, eternal life or the abode of the hereafter and resurrection will be necessary, because if there were no resurrection and hereafter, the desire for survival and immortality-seeking and the gift of eternity-wanting in human nature would be futile and vain, and the Wise God does not do vain and futile work. It is impossible that there should be a desire for water in human nature but no water. If humans were aware of the moment of their death, years before the arrival of the moment of death, sorrow and grief and coldness and silence would rule over them so much that it would deprive them of any kind of movement and effort.

Ignorance of the moment of death also has an educational aspect, because choosing the right path is considered a sign of spiritual perfection when humans feel they are capable of performing or abandoning an action, not on the day when they see the sun of their life on the rooftop. Ignorance of the time of death can also be beneficial in another way in building the human soul: if humans were aware of the moment of their death, perhaps the spirit of rebellion and disobedience to God would be strengthened with the hope of repentance in the final moments; but if the time of death is unknown to humans, they sin less, because they cannot give themselves the hope of future repentance. The Qur'an says in this regard:

Faydh Kashani presents the proof of innate nature as follows:

"How is it possible for human souls to be annihilated, when God, according to the requirement of His wisdom, has placed love of existence and survival in human nature and has placed aversion to non-existence and annihilation in their being and nature of life? Existence is pure good and pure light. On the other hand, it is established and certain that survival and permanence in this world is impossible: 'Wherever you are, death will overtake you.' If there is no other world to which humans transfer, this instinct that God has placed in human nature—meaning love of existence and eternal survival and love of everlasting life—will be futile and wasted; whereas God is exalted above doing futile work."

Imam Khomeini (may his spirit be sanctified) presents the proof of innate nature for proving resurrection as follows:

"One of the divine innate natures with which all the human family and the human chain are endowed is the innate nature of love for comfort. Since absolute comfort is not found in this world... therefore, necessarily in the house of realization and the world of

existence, there must be a world whose comfort is not attributed to hardship and difficulty... and that is the true abode of blessing and the world of honor of the Sacred Essence."

In humans, there is a desire for eternity and also the capacity for eternity and survival for their immaterial soul. Now if the conditions and ground for this kind of life are not provided for them, their creation will be vain and futile. And since the Wise and Self-Sufficient God is the Creator of humans and the world and does not do any vain and futile work, undoubtedly He has prepared the appropriate conditions and ground for human eternity. Therefore, apart from the material and temporary world, there is also an eternal abode where humans will live eternally. The verses of the Qur'an that refer to this proof are:

"Then did you think that We created you uselessly and that to Us you would not be returned?" (Qur'an 23:115)

"Does man think that he will be left neglected? ... Is not that [Creator] Able to give life to the dead?" (Qur'an 75:36, 40)

2. The Proof of Justice

Among God's attributes is justice, and His creation is also based on justice, as the Prophet (peace be upon him) and Commander of the Faithful (peace be upon him) have explicitly stated this truth:

"By justice the heavens and earth were raised."

"Justice is a foundation upon which the world is established."

God does not oppress anyone and treats all humans justly:

"Indeed, God does not do injustice to the people at all." (Qur'an 10:44)

Nevertheless, we see in the world that virtuous humans have not received the reward for their actions, and on the other hand, evil humans also do not receive punishment for their actions. How can one who has killed thousands of innocents be punished? Many of their crimes remain unpunished. Therefore, since the world does not have the capacity for the realization of justice, and on the other hand, since God is just and does not allow injustice to anyone, and in His presence, oppressors and evildoers are not equal to the good, and He gives reward and punishment for every action appropriately, there must be another world that will manifest God's justice, and there reward and punishment will be given to each person according to their actions. Commander of the Faithful (peace be upon him) says in this regard:

"Indeed, God Almighty has not approved it as a reward for His friends, nor as a punishment for His enemies."

Some of the verses that indicate this truth and testify that God does not consider evildoers and the righteous equal are:

"Then will We treat the Muslims like the criminals? What is [the matter] with you? How do you judge? Or should we treat those who believe and do righteous deeds like corrupters in the land? Or should We treat those who fear God like the wicked?" (Qur'an 38:28)

God in this verse, with a tone of surprise, denies equality in punishment and reward and considers it incompatible with divine justice.

"Or do those who commit evils think We will make them like those who have believed and done righteous deeds - [make them] equal in their life and their death? Evil is that which they judge." (Qur'an 45:21)

3. The Proof of Rationality

One of the ways humans can find the truth of resurrection is the proof of rationality, which in the past was referred to as "repelling possible harm." If humans place belief in resurrection and non-belief in resurrection side by side and calculate the advantages and disadvantages of each, they will realize that belief in resurrection has greater preference. Therefore, belief in resurrection is more rational.

Wherever humans suspect material and worldly harm and loss, they strive with all their might to remove it, and reason commands caution in such cases; for example, you are going mountain climbing and plan to return the same day; but if someone tells you that obstacles may arise for you that prevent you from returning on time, since you consider the possibility of delay, you take necessary water and food with you lest you fall into difficulty from hunger and thirst.

Now, thousands of prophets who were famous for truthfulness have informed humans that a great day and a shocking event and another world lie ahead. Should humans not be cautious and take the necessary means with them out of precaution? If there is no other world, we have not suffered loss, and if there is—which definite proofs also testify to it—those who have not gone with the necessary preparation will suffer loss.

Imam Rida (peace be upon him) has also alluded to this meaning in a narration in conversation with a denier of resurrection.

D) Types of Resurrection

So far it has been established that humans consist of two dimensions, material and immaterial, and the immaterial soul, which constitutes the reality and true personality of humans, is not destroyed by death, and the divine angels take this spiritual reality from humans. Thus the soul remains. Now the question is: what is life after death like? Is resurrection spiritual or both physical and spiritual?

1. Physical and Spiritual Resurrection

Before we answer this question, we need to clarify the meaning of physical and spiritual resurrection.

First: Some believe that after death and even in resurrection, only the abstract soul is resurrected, and the body to which the soul was attached no longer enters the resurrection. In this sense, resurrection is called "spiritual." Others believe that in addition to the abstract soul remaining, the material body is also attached to it again, and both become the subject of rewards and punishments. But that only the material body is resurrected in resurrection, given the acceptance of the immaterial soul which is the reality of humanity, is not conceivable.

Second: Sometimes what is meant by physical and spiritual is that the body or soul alone, or both, become the object of reward and punishment. Therefore, physical resurrection means that unless there is a body present, reward and punishment will not be realized, like pleasure obtained through the body. This type of resurrection is called "physical"; but if in addition to such physical pleasures and pains, there is also a series of spiritual and intellectual rewards and punishments and pains that the soul never needs the body and physical faculties to perceive, this is called "spiritual resurrection."

2. Types of Resurrection in the Qur'an

From the Qur'anic viewpoint, resurrection means being raised and brought back to life again—both soul and body together. Those who believe that in the hereafter only the soul alone is resurrected, their view is contrary to the Qur'anic view.

The verses that testify that in addition to the soul, the material body will also be resurrected are:

First: Verses that speak of the revival of the dead in previous nations, such as the revival of birds through the prayer of Prophet Abraham (peace be upon him), the story of the People of the Cave, the revival of Uzair, and the revival of the dead through the prayer of Prophet Jesus (peace be upon him).

Given these verses, one cannot say that the quality of the otherworldly body is like the barzakh body and imaginal forms that the soul creates with its creativity; rather, worldly

bodies will be raised. Otherwise, all these similes and approximations lose their eloquence, and the relationship between resurrection and the dead brought back to life by the prophets is lost.

Second: Verses that clearly testify that humans are created from dust and will return to it again, and then will come out of it:

"From the earth We created you, and into it We will return you, and from it We will extract you another time." (Qur'an 20:55)

Third: Verses that show that on the Day of Resurrection, the parts of the human body will testify to their actions, and interpreting these parts as barzakh parts and immaterial forms is completely contrary to the apparent meaning of the verses:

"On a Day when their tongues, their hands and their feet will bear witness against them as to what they used to do." (Qur'an 24:24)

From these statements it becomes clear that the view of those who believe only in spiritual resurrection is contrary to the Qur'anic view, because the resurrection of the body from the Qur'anic perspective is definite and certain, and there is no room for any doubt about it.

Also, from the Qur'anic viewpoint, in addition to sensory rewards and punishments and physical pleasures and pains, there are also spiritual and non-sensory rewards and punishments for the righteous and evildoers, for perceiving which the soul does not need the body and sensory faculties. Regarding physical pleasures and pains, Surah al-Waqi'ah, with the promises and threats and rewards and punishments it has stated for three groups—"the brought near," "companions of the right," and "companions of the left"—is clear testimony.

From all that has been said, it appears that according to the Qur'anic view, human resurrection is both physical and spiritual, and on the Day of Resurrection both the material body and human soul will be resurrected, and human pleasures and pains in resurrection are both physical and spiritual.

Chapter Two: Death

A) The Nature of Death

Death is a window to new life. Death is another stage of life and the beginning of a new human life. The noble Prophet of Islam (peace be upon him) says: Death is the first station of the stations of the hereafter and the last station of the stations of this world. Therefore, familiarity with the characteristics of this station from the Qur'anic viewpoint is appropriate and necessary.

1. The Linguistic Meaning of Death

"Marg" (death) in Persian is equivalent to the word "mawt" in Arabic. Mawt means the loss of power and capability of something. Sometimes death is used for the body and sometimes for the soul. When it is used for the body, the meaning is that the body has lost any kind of movement and motion; whereas if death is attributed to the soul, the meaning is that the soul has lost its physical instrument, and in reality there is no non-existence involved, and it is a transfer from one stage to another stage of life. Therefore, the use of the word death for humans means that their body has lost its capability of being an instrument for the soul, and they have separated from each other.

2. Is Death a Matter of Non-existence?

At the moment of death, angels take the immaterial soul, and after that, the parts of the body disintegrate. Thus, the reality of the human—which is the soul—enters another stage of life from one stage.

Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says:

"O people! We and you were created for survival, not for annihilation, and when we die, we are transferred from one abode to another abode."

Imam Husayn (peace be upon him) addressed his companions:

"Young men, be patient! Death is but a bridge that transfers you from hardships and difficulties to vast gardens and continuous blessings. Which one of you dislikes transfer from prison to palace!"

3. Death: A Definite and Universal Tradition

From the perspective of the Qur'an and Islamic narrations, human death and the death of the world is an inevitable tradition, and there is no escape from it. The Qur'an says:

"Every soul will taste death." (Qur'an 3:185)

"Wherever you may be, death will overtake you, even if you should be within towers of lofty construction." (Qur'an 4:78)

4. Fear of Death

Many humans, because they do not believe in resurrection, are unaware of the reality of death, fear the punishment for their sins, etc., they fear death. Some consider death as the end of life, and with death all their existence is annihilated. Therefore, they fear non-existence; but those who have certainty about resurrection and consider death as a new stage of life do not allow any fear of it into their hearts.

Of course, a kind of anxiety about death can be observed in everyone, because separation from loved ones, such as spouse, father, mother, children, and friends, will not be without pain. This kind of anxiety is natural and exists in all humans at the moment of death. Now let us refer to some narrations in this regard:

A man came to the presence of the Prophet (peace be upon him) and said: "I do not like death." The Prophet (peace be upon him) asked him: "Do you have any wealth?" He said: "Yes." He said: "Have you sent anything for yourself to the other abode?" He said: "No." The Prophet (peace be upon him) said: "That is why you do not like death."

It is narrated that Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), said: "Do not be among those who do not like death due to the abundance of sins."

It is also narrated that a man said to Imam Mujtaba (peace be upon him): "Why don't we like death?" The Imam said: "You have destroyed the house of the hereafter and built the house of this world. You do not like to transfer from the built house to the ruin."

A man said to Imam Jawad (peace be upon him): "Why don't some Muslims like death?" He said: "Because they did not know it. If they knew it and were among God's friends, they would have loved it and would have known that the abode of the hereafter is better for them than this world." Of course, God's friends never allow fear of death into their hearts; rather, they go to meet it.

Commander of the Faithful, Ali (peace be upon him), says about death:

"By God, the son of Abu Talib is more familiar with death than a nursing infant is with its mother's breast."

He also says:

"By God, I do not fear whether I enter upon death or death comes to me."

B) Types of Death

1. Difficult and Easy Deaths

From the Qur'an and narrations it appears that angels do not take the souls of all humans in the same way; rather, they take some with respect and ease, and they take others with harshness and difficulty.

Easy death is generally for the righteous and believers. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"Those whom the angels take in death, [being] good and pure; [the angels] will say, 'Peace be upon you. Enter Paradise for what you used to do.'" (Qur'an 16:32)

Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) also says in this regard:

"Death for the believer is like smelling a pleasant fragrance, through the pleasure of which they fall into light sleep, and all pains depart from them."

Difficult death is generally for oppressors and wrongdoers. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"Then how [will it be] when the angels take them in death, striking their faces and their backs?" (Qur'an 47:27)

Imam Sajjad (peace be upon him) also describes the death of a disbeliever as follows:

"Death for disbelievers is like removing beautiful and precious clothes and wearing the filthiest and roughest clothes, or transferring from familiar houses and settling in the most terrifying dwellings with the greatest torments."

2. Death of Body and Heart

From the Qur'anic viewpoint, death befalls both the body and the heart. When the connection of the soul with the body is severed, bodily death occurs; but when humans, in terms of thought and reasoning, are at a very low level and do not have listening ears for the words of truth, their heart dies. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"Indeed, you will not make the dead hear, nor will you make the deaf hear the call when they have turned their backs retreating." (Qur'an 27:80)

Imam Ali (peace be upon him) also says in this regard:

"Those who have completely abandoned forbidding evil and do not fight against evil, neither with tongue nor with heart nor with hand, are the living dead."

3. Death of Individual and Society

The Qur'an considers death for society, like for individuals. The death of society occurs due to oppression, wrongdoing, sin, and disobedience to God. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And for every nation is a [specified] term. So when their time has come, they will not remain behind an hour, nor will they precede [it]." (Qur'an 7:34)

"And your Lord would not have destroyed the cities unjustly while their people were reformers." (Qur'an 11:117)

4. Honorable Death

Among deaths, there is a type that humans should be proud of, and that is death in the path of God, establishing justice and equity, acquiring knowledge and learning, earning lawful sustenance, and acquiring divine knowledge. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And never think of those who have been killed in the cause of God as dead. Rather, they are alive with their Lord, receiving provision." (Qur'an 2:154)

C) Repentance and Will at the Time of Death

1. Repentance of the Dying Person

From the Qur'anic perspective, at the time of death, the material veils are lifted from the eyes, and humans can become aware of their destiny in the other abode. For this reason, the righteous go to meet death, while sinners become very regretful and want to repent.

According to Qur'anic verses, repentance and faith at the moment of death are not accepted, because repentance and regret are a cause of spiritual perfection when the regretful person is capable of committing the sin; but when power and capability have been taken from them and they have only one path before them, regret does not indicate spiritual transformation. And this kind of regret and repentance has an essential difference from regrets and repentances before the moments of death. The Qur'an says:

"But repentance is not [accepted] of those who [continue to] do evil deeds up until, when death comes to one of them, he says, 'Indeed, I have repented now.'" (Qur'an 4:18)

Also, the Qur'an quotes from disbelievers and evildoers:

"[For such is the state of the disbelievers], until, when death comes to one of them, he says, 'My Lord, send me back that I might do righteousness in that which I left behind.'" (Qur'an 23:99-100)

The noble Qur'an narrates that Pharaoh of Egypt, when drowning in the sea, repented and professed faith, but God did not accept his repentance:

"And We took the Children of Israel across the sea, and Pharaoh and his soldiers pursued them in tyranny and enmity until, when drowning overtook him, he said, 'I believe that there is no deity except that in whom the Children of Israel believe, and I am of the Muslims.' Now? And you had disobeyed [Him] before and were of the corrupters?" (Qur'an 10:90-91)

2. Will at the Time of Death

Among the divine commands is that every Muslim should make a will about their property at the time of death, and two just witnesses should also testify to the will; although according to Islamic narrations, it is appropriate for a Muslim to have their will under their pillow when they sleep at night. The Qur'an says:

"Prescribed for you when death approaches [any] one of you if he leaves wealth - [is that he should make] a bequest." (Qur'an 2:180)

Among God's kindnesses to humans is that they are not aware of the moment of their death. If humans were aware of the time and place of their death, years before the arrival of the moment of death, sorrow and grief and coldness and silence would rule over them so much that it would deprive them of any kind of movement and effort.

Ignorance of the moment of death also has an educational aspect, because choosing the right path is considered a sign of spiritual perfection when humans feel they are capable of performing or abandoning an action, not on the day when they see the sun of their life on the rooftop. Ignorance of the time of death can also be beneficial in another way in building the human soul: if humans were aware of the moment of their death, perhaps the spirit of rebellion and disobedience to God would be strengthened with the hope of repentance in the final moments; but if the time of death is unknown to humans, they sin less, because they cannot give themselves the hope of future repentance. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And no soul perceives in what land it will die." (Qur'an 31:34)

Chapter 3: After Death

A) The Grave and the World of Barzakh

If we consider the moment of death as the first station of human life after this world, then descent into the grave must be counted as the second station. Of course, the grave has an outward meaning—the pit in which the human body is buried—and a true meaning, which is Barzakh itself. Therefore, from the Qur'an's perspective, the second station of humanity is Barzakh, which is sometimes called the world of the grave and sometimes the world of Barzakh. The Qur'an states in this regard:

"And before them is a barrier (barzakh) until the Day they are resurrected." (23:100)

Barzakh is something that stands as a barrier between two things, and for this reason, the world that lies between this world and the Hereafter is called "Barzakh." Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) called the world of Barzakh the interval between death and the Day of Judgment. A man asked the Imam what Barzakh is. The Imam said: "What is meant by Barzakh is the human grave from the moment of death until the Day of Resurrection."

From the time of death, a person enters the world of Barzakh, whether they are buried in the earth, burned by fire, become food for wild animals, or drown in the sea. In this world, humans continue their life with a Barzakh body and experience pleasure and joy or pain and torment more or less in proportion to their deeds.

In the world of Barzakh, two angels named Nakir and Munkar question the person. But what do they ask about? A narration from Imam Sajjad (peace be upon him) has been related on this matter, to which we refer:

His Holiness would preach to the people every Friday, saying among other things: "O child of Adam! Do not be heedless of death. Soon your soul will be taken. You will be transferred to a station. Your soul will be returned to you, and two angels named Munkar and Nakir will come to you to question you. The first thing they will ask about is your Lord. Then about the Prophet who was sent to you, and about the religion you accepted, and about the book you recited, and about the Imam whose authority you accepted. Then they will ask about your life—in what path you spent it, and about your wealth and property—where you earned it from and in what path you spent it."

B) The Portrait of Resurrection

From the Qur'an it is clearly evident that the establishment of the Hereafter or the world of the afterlife is not limited solely to the resurrection of humans. Rather, along with it, a series of events occur, which we will briefly mention some of them:

1. The State of Earth, Seas, and Mountains

On the Day of Resurrection, a severe earthquake will grip the earth. Whatever has appeared on earth will crumble. The surface of the earth becomes visible and apparent. The earth splits open and the dead emerge from it to be resurrected at the Resurrection. The seas split apart and become boiling and inflamed. Mountains are uprooted and move in an unbalanced manner, appearing like heaps of earth, becoming like carded wool—soft and flexible—and finally scattering like dust particles. Of the mountain chains reaching to the sky, nothing remains but a mirage.

2. The State of Heaven and Stars

The heavenly state is transformed and the stars are torn from their places. The sky undergoes a kind of wave motion and movement, becoming torn and split, appearing like red roses, oil, and molten metal flowing, and finally appearing like smoke, folding up. The light of the sun and moon fades to darkness. Their order is disrupted and they are hurled toward the earth.

3. The Blowing of the Trumpet

In verses and narrations, one of the signs of the Resurrection is "the blowing of the trumpet," which consists of two blasts: one is the blast of death, which occurs before the general Resurrection—that is, before the establishment of the Resurrection, a tremendous sound will reach the ears of all creatures, causing the death of all of them, and through it the order of the world is disrupted. The other is the blast of life, when the Resurrection is established and the scene of the world is illuminated by God's light, and all humans and even animals are brought to life in an instant. The Qur'an says about the blowing of the trumpet:

"And the trumpet will be blown, and whoever is in the heavens and whoever is on the earth will fall dead except whom Allah wills. Then it will be blown again, and at once they will be standing, looking on." (39:68)

C) Descriptions of the Resurrection

The Qur'an has enumerated various names and descriptions for the Resurrection, each pointing to a reality. Some of them include:

1. **Inevitable and Certain:** The Qur'an considers the Resurrection as something about which there is no doubt in its occurrence.
2. **Nearness:** The Qur'an considers the Resurrection near, and in some expressions refers to it with the word "tomorrow," because since it is near, the expression "tomorrow" can be used for it.
3. **Truth:** The Qur'an considers the Resurrection the Day of Truth—a day when absolute truth appears and there is no place for falsehood, and everyone reaches their right.
4. **Great News:** The Qur'an refers to the Resurrection as "great news" and also with the expression "great day," because great events occur on it, and also with the expression "grand day."
5. **Calling with a Leader:** The Day of Resurrection is a day when everyone is called by the name of their leader, and this person is the prophet of that nation.
6. **Crying Out:** The scene of the Resurrection is called "the Day of Crying" and Yawm al-Tanad. This name is because the people of Hell call out to the people of Paradise.
7. **Fleeing from Relatives, Severing of Ties, and Separation:** The Qur'an considers the Resurrection "the Day of Fleeing"—a day when a person flees from their brother, mother, father, spouse, and children, and everyone is occupied with their own affairs, and in other words, it is the day of severing ties.
8. **Aging:** The Resurrection is a day when children and adolescents become old. The reason for this may be the length or difficulty of the events of that day.
9. **Revealing of Secrets:** In the Resurrection, all secrets and human deeds are revealed, and believers and evildoers are recognized by their faces, and the record of human deeds is opened—a book in which all deeds are recorded, and everyone sees every good and bad deed they have done.
10. **Uselessness of Wealth and Children:** In the Resurrection, wealth and children bring no benefit to humans. What is meant by wealth and children are worldly adornments that are not beneficial in the Hereafter; rather, what is beneficial and useful is righteous deeds.
11. **Non-acceptance of Excuses:** The excuses and pretexts of oppressors and wrongdoers are not accepted in the Resurrection, and they are not even given permission to make excuses.
12. **Regret:** In the Resurrection, humans feel regret about their past and suffer pain that they spent their precious life in idleness and disobedience to God, and evildoers even bite their hands in regret.

D) Divine Reckoning

One of the Qur'anic names for the Resurrection is "the Day of Reckoning"—that is, the day when God settles the accounts of His servants' deeds. Those who have done good works will pursue a happy life, and conversely, those who in this world engaged in oppression, transgression, and improper deeds will have a miserable life. It is narrated that "this world is the farm of the Hereafter," meaning whatever we plant in this farm, we will harvest in the Hereafter.

The purpose of reckoning with servants is for God's justice and wisdom to be manifested so that no excuse or pretext remains; otherwise, God is aware of the hidden and apparent deeds of everyone. There are several points worth mentioning about the reckoning of servants' deeds:

1. The Reckoner

Who settles the accounts of servants in the Hereafter?

Some verses indicate that God Himself examines the deeds of His servants, as He says:

"Indeed, to Us is their return. Then indeed, upon Us is their account." (88:25-26)

"Sufficient is Allah as accountant." (4:6)

However, according to some other verses, the human soul itself is sufficient for reckoning, as it says:

"And [for] every person We have imposed his fate upon his neck, and We will produce for him on the Day of Resurrection a record which he will encounter spread open. [It will be said], 'Read your record. Sufficient is yourself against you this Day as accountant.'" (17:13-14)

This verse is not incompatible with previous verses, because the reckoning of servants is with God, but this verse speaks of how the reckoning occurs—that is, all human deeds appear in the form of a book before their eyes, and humans observe the reality of what they have done in this world. Also, the reckoning is so precise and fair that there is no room for any denial, and in reality, humans themselves testify to their good and bad deeds and confirm God's reckoning.

2. The Subject of Reckoning

What deeds will be questioned in the Hereafter?

From the verses of the Qur'an, it appears that all human deeds are the subject of questioning and reckoning, as the Qur'an says:

"And you will surely be questioned about what you used to do." (16:93)

From this and other verses, it appears that all human deeds are the subject of divine questioning and reckoning. However, in other verses and narrations, more emphasis has been placed on questioning certain deeds due to their importance, which include: divine blessings, the Qur'an, testimonies and witnesses, killing of innocents, lies and slanders, truthfulness of the truthful, how one used the organs and limbs of the body, prayer, human life, youth period, acquiring wealth and spending it, love of the Ahl al-Bayt, and how one treated the Prophet and Ahl al-Bayt.

Therefore, in the Resurrection, God questions all human deeds, and emphasis on certain deeds in verses and narrations does not contradict this fact. Imam Ali (peace be upon him) says:

"In its lawful [enjoyment] there is reckoning, and in its unlawful [enjoyment] there is punishment."

3. Completion of Proof

God's reckoning is such that the proof is completed upon the servants and no human can make excuses for their sins. Imam Baqir (peace be upon him) says in this regard:

"On the Day of Resurrection, God will say to the sinner: Were you aware of the wrongness of this deed? If he says yes, He will say: Why did you not act according to your knowledge? If he says: I did not know, he will be addressed: Why did you not learn so you could act upon it? Thus in the position of argumentation, the sinful servant is defeated, and it is God who has proof over His servants."

Also, in some narrations, it has been stated that sinners cannot make beauty, poverty, and misfortune an excuse for sin to escape punishment. Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) says in this regard:

"On the Day of Resurrection, they will bring a beautiful woman who fell into the trap of sin because of her beauty, for reckoning, and she makes an excuse based on her beauty, saying: Lord! You created me beautiful and this caused my deviation. She is told: Mary was more beautiful than you and she protected her chastity. Also, a handsome man who committed sin is brought. He too makes an excuse based on his handsomeness, but he is answered: Joseph was more handsome than you, but he did not sin."

Likewise, someone who became subject to error due to life difficulties and many afflictions makes an excuse based on their wretchedness and misfortune, but he is answered: Job had greater afflictions, but he did not become polluted with sin."

E) The Scale (Mizan)

One of the topics related to the Resurrection is "the scale"—that is, in the Resurrection, the good and bad deeds of humans are weighed, and those whose good deeds are heavier are saved, and those whose good deeds are light will be in Hell. The Qur'an says:

"And We place the scales of justice for the Day of Resurrection, so no soul will be treated unjustly at all. And if there is [even] the weight of a mustard seed, We will bring it forth. And sufficient are We as accountant." (21:47)

"Then as for one whose scales are heavy [with good deeds], he will be in a pleasant life. But as for one whose scales are light, his refuge will be an abyss." (101:6-9)

There are several points worth mentioning about the scale:

1. The Meaning of the Scale

In our daily lives, we are familiar with various types of scales and measuring instruments, such as balances, rulers, plumb lines, levels, odometers, barometers, anemometers, thermometers, meters, and pressure gauges. However, the scale and measuring instrument for deeds on the Day of Resurrection is not similar to any of these.

The criterion for measuring deeds on that day is truth. Every deed that is accompanied by truth is heavier—as if on the Day of Resurrection, truth is embodied and deeds are presented upon it, and then the destiny of humans is determined. Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him), in interpreting the verse "And We place the scales of justice...", says:

"The scales are indeed the Prophets and their successors..."

Thus, everyone's deeds are presented upon the deeds of the Prophets and successors, and the standard, criterion, and scale for each nation is the deed of the prophet and the prophet's successor of that nation.

The Qur'an calls the Prophet the exemplar and model for humans. Just as his deeds, beliefs, ethics, and conduct are the model and criterion of truth and falsehood in this world, on the Day of Resurrection too, the scale and measuring instrument is human deeds.

2. The Scale for People of Faith

From the Qur'an and narrations, it appears that the scale is for people of faith. For polytheists and sinners who have destroyed all their good works as a result of some sins, and for those who have no resemblance to the Prophets, there will be no scale. The Qur'an says:

"And We will not assign to them on the Day of Resurrection any weight." (18:105)

F) Witnesses on the Day of Resurrection

God does not need witnesses, but from an educational perspective, the existence of witnesses is very beneficial. If humans knew that many witnesses observe their deeds and will testify on the Day of Resurrection, perhaps they would refrain from evil deeds. For example, if someone knew that many cameras are recording all their actions, they would be more careful.

The Qur'an considers the Day of Resurrection as the day of God's court—a day when witnesses stand up and testify:

"The Day when the witnesses will stand..." (40:51)

The witnesses of the Resurrection are many. Some of them include:

1. God

The first witness of human deeds is God, who is aware of all their hidden and apparent deeds, as the Qur'an says:

"Say, 'O People of the Scripture, why do you disbelieve in the verses of Allah while Allah is Witness over what you do?'" (3:98)

"And Allah is witness over all things." (22:17)

2. Divine Prophets

The Qur'an clearly reminds us that on the Day of Resurrection, an individual from each nation will testify to the deeds of their people, and this person is the prophet of that nation:

"And [mention] the Day when We will resurrect among every nation a witness over them from themselves. And We will bring you, [O Muhammad], as a witness over these." (16:89)

From this verse it is clearly apparent that God raises from each nation the prophet of that nation to testify to the nation's deeds, and the noble Prophet of Islam is also a witness over these witnesses.

"And thus we have made you a just community that you will be witnesses over the people and the Messenger will be a witness over you." (2:143)

"O Prophet, indeed We have sent you as a witness and a bringer of good tidings and a warner." (33:45)

From these verses it is clearly apparent that the Prophet is among the witnesses of the Day of Resurrection, and also from the first verse it appears that some chosen ones of the Islamic nation are also among the witnesses of the Day of Resurrection. In Islamic narrations, it has been stated that what is meant by these chosen ones are the Infallibles (peace be upon them).

3. Angels

Another witness is the angels who observe people's deeds in this world and enter God's court with them in the Resurrection. One of the angels brings the sinner to the court and another is a witness to their deeds. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And every soul will come, with it a driver and a witness." (50:21)

4. Earth

The earth or place is also among the witnesses of the Day of Resurrection. Every good and bad deed performed upon it is recorded in it, and on the Day of Resurrection, by God's command, it reveals it. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"That Day, it will report its news." (99:4)

The noble Prophet (peace and blessings be upon him) also says in this regard:

"On the Day of Resurrection, the earth will testify to every deed committed by a man or woman upon it, saying: He performed such-and-such deed on such-and-such day."

5. Time

Time also records events in itself and reveals them in the Resurrection by God's command. Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) says in a narration:

"Every day that arrives addresses the children of Adam: Do good deeds so that I may testify in your favor in the Resurrection. I am an impermanent being; I did not exist in the

past and will not exist in the future. And when darkness arrives, the night says the same."

Imam Sajjad (peace be upon him) also says in this regard:

"This is a new, occurring day and it is a witness and ready witness over us."

6. The Qur'an

From some narrations, it can be understood that the Qur'an appears in human form on the Day of Resurrection, and God addresses it: How did you find My servants? In response, it says: Lord! A group of them memorized me and did not destroy anything of me, and some destroyed me, considered my right insignificant, and rose to deny me, and I am Your proof over all people. At this time, the address comes: By My glory and majesty, I swear that because of you I will give the first group the best reward, and I will subject the second group to painful punishment.

7. The Record of Deeds

Among the witnesses of the Day of Resurrection is the record of deeds in which good and bad deeds are recorded. The Qur'an refers to this record in several verses:

"Our messengers record what they conspire." (10:21)

"Or do they think that We hear not their secrets and their private conversations? Yes, [We do], and Our messengers are with them recording." (43:80)

Therefore, all human deeds are recorded in the record of deeds, and in the Resurrection this record is hung around the person's neck. The Qur'an says:

"And [for] every person We have imposed his fate upon his neck." (17:13)

What is meant by internal witnesses are witnesses that are part of the human body or are connected to them in some way.

8. Body Parts

One of the wonders of the Resurrection is that the organs of the criminal's body testify to their sin, and there remains no room for any excuse, doubt, or uncertainty. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"On a Day when their tongues, their hands and their feet will bear witness against them as to what they used to do." (24:24)

9. Skin

One of the witnesses of the Day of Resurrection is the skin of the body, which plays a role in every action, even more comprehensive than other body parts. Every evil deed that sinners perform in this world is recorded in the skin of the body, and in the Resurrection, by God's command, it reveals everything. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"On the Day when the enemies of Allah will be gathered to the Fire while they are [driven], assembled in rows, until, when they reach it, their hearing and their eyes and their skins will testify against them of what they used to do. And they will say to their skins, 'Why have you testified against us?' They will say, 'We were made to speak by Allah, who has made everything speak; and He created you the first time, and to Him you are returned.'" (41:19-21)

G) Embodiment of Deeds

The topic of embodiment of deeds relates both to reward and punishment in the Hereafter and to witnesses on the Day of Resurrection, because the embodiment of a deed is the best witness to the deed. Embodiment of deeds means that the good and bad deeds of humans have a worldly form that we observe, and also a Hereafter form that is currently hidden in the heart and essence of the deed.

Human deeds on the Day of Resurrection, after transformations and evolutions that occur, lose their current form and appear as the reality of the Hereafter, causing pleasure and joy or suffering and sorrow for humans. Even intentions and soul traits of humans are also embodied in the world of the Hereafter.

Those over whom lust and anger dominate and whose deeds constantly arise from these two instincts—their Hereafter form is an animal and beast. And if trickery and deception are in a person's works, their Hereafter form is Satan. And if praiseworthy ethics take root in their soul, they are manifested in beautiful paradisiacal forms.

The Qur'an clearly mentions the embodiment of deeds and says:

"The Day every soul will find what it has done of good present [before it] and what it has done of evil, it will wish that between itself and that [evil] was a great distance." (3:30)

"So whoever does an atom's weight of good will see it, and whoever does an atom's weight of evil will see it." (99:7-8)

From these two verses it is clearly apparent that deeds are present in the Resurrection and humans become aware of them and see the deed itself, not its reward and

punishment. Also, the Qur'an indicates in verses that concealing divine truths and oppressing orphans, although outwardly accompanied by worldly pleasures and the apparent eye sees only joys and pleasures, their inner reality is fire.

"Indeed, those who devour the property of orphans unjustly are only consuming into their bellies fire. And they will be burned in a Blaze." (4:10)

The embodiment of deeds is also mentioned in narrations.

The noble Messenger (peace and blessings be upon him) said: "Beware of oppression, for oppression appears as darkenesses on the Day of Resurrection."

Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) said: "When a believer is placed in the grave, a door from the unseen world is opened to him and he sees his place in Paradise, and in this state he looks at a beautiful man more beautiful than anyone he has seen. He says to him: Who are you? In response he says: I am your good intention or praiseworthy belief and worthy deed..."

Chapter 4: Paradise and Hell

Paradise is the place that God has prepared for the righteous, and all blessings are found in it. Some of these blessings have been mentioned in the Qur'an. The purpose of mentioning them is only to depict Paradise for humans as much as possible, because the blessings and joys of Paradise have a fundamental difference from the blessings of this world, and the expressions of this world do not have the power to interpret the realities of Paradise—just as a fetus in the mother's womb does not have the power to understand the realities of this world. Hell is also a place where sinners and oppressors are subjected to various punishments.

The Qur'an has enumerated descriptions for Hell that, like the descriptions of Paradise, are for bringing it closer to the mind, and the reality of Hell cannot be comprehended by humans through conventional expressions.

A) The Current Creation of Paradise and Hell

From the verses of the Qur'an and narrations, it is clearly apparent that God has already created Paradise and Hell and prepared them for the righteous and sinners. The verses that indicate this reality include:

"And he certainly saw him in another descent at the Lote Tree of the Utmost Boundary – Near it is the Garden of Refuge." (53:13-15)

What is meant by "the Garden of Refuge" is the promised Paradise that other verses have referred to as "Gardens of Eternity" and the like. If Paradise had not been created, such an expression would be far from eloquence and rhetoric.

Other verses have also given news of Paradise and Hell being prepared for the righteous and evildoers, which are evidence of their current existence:

"And hasten to forgiveness from your Lord and a garden as wide as the heavens and earth, prepared for the righteous." (3:133)

"And fear the Fire, which has been prepared for the disbelievers." (3:131)

From these verses, one can clearly understand that Paradise and Hell are now prepared for the righteous and disbelievers.

Also, narrations indicate the existence of Paradise and Hell from now. Among them is the following narration:

"Harawi has narrated from Imam Reza (peace be upon him) that he said to His Holiness: O son of the Prophet of God! Tell me about Paradise and Hell; have they been created now? He said: Yes, when the Messenger of God ascended to the heavens, he saw Paradise and Hell. A group says that Paradise and Hell are within the realm of God's decree and will be created in the future.

He said: They are not from us and we are not from them. Whoever denies the creation of Paradise and Hell has denied the Prophet and us and has gone out from our authority and will be in eternal fire."

In another narration, Imam Sadiq (peace be upon him) has stated:

"Anyone who denies four things is not our Shi'a: the Ascension, the questioning in the grave, the existence of Paradise and Hell, and intercession."

B) The Path to Reaching Paradise

In general, it can be said that every good deed done for God's pleasure guides humans to Paradise. Some good deeds are commanded by human reason, and others are commanded by God, and even God's commands also confirm the rulings of reason. God's commands have come in the Qur'an and the narrations of the Prophet and the Infallible Imams, and they have mentioned deeds, some of which we should mention:

1. Faith and Righteous Deeds

Faith and righteous deeds are among the deeds that guide humans to Paradise. The Qur'an says in this regard:

"And those who believe and do righteous deeds – those are the companions of Paradise; they will abide therein eternally." (2:82)

2. Following God and the Messenger

Whoever follows the commands and prohibitions of God and His Messenger, God will bring him into Paradise, and whoever disobeys God and His Messenger, God will take him to Hell. The Qur'an says:

"And whoever obeys Allah and His Messenger will be admitted by Him to gardens... But whoever disobeys Allah and His Messenger and transgresses His limits – He will put him into the Fire to abide eternally therein, and he will have a humiliating punishment." (4:13-14)

3. Truthfulness

The Qur'an enumerates attributes for the truthful as well as the pious and righteous. The common attributes of the truthful, pious, and righteous can be mentioned as follows:

Belief in God, the Hereafter, angels, heavenly books, and divine prophets, as well as spending on relatives, orphans, the poor, travelers, and honorable needy people, establishing prayer, paying zakat, fulfilling covenants and promises, and patience in hardship and difficulty.

According to Qur'anic verses, those who adorn themselves with these deeds and valuable conduct are people of truthfulness and piety:

"Those are the ones who have been true, and it is those who are the righteous." (2:177)

4. Righteousness

God takes the righteous to Paradise. But righteousness is a deed that provides God's pleasure. Either God has inspired righteousness to the human heart and conscience, or He has shown it to His Prophet and it is recorded in the Qur'an and narrations. The Qur'an says:

"Indeed, the righteous will be in pleasure. And indeed, the wicked will be in Hellfire." (82:13-14)

5. Patience

Those who practice patience in the way of God are not a separate group from the pious and righteous. That patience is separately praised in verses and narrations is due to its great importance, and their importance is also due to their patience and steadfastness before God. The Qur'an praises the patient, saying:

"Peace be upon you for what you patiently endured. And excellent is the final home." (13:24)

6. Maintaining Prayer

Those who never abandon prayer and honor the time and necessary conditions in performing it, and who have understood its spirit and reality and do not prefer anything over this divine obligation, are praised in the Qur'an, and their eternal abode is Paradise. The Qur'an says:

"And they who carefully maintain their prayers – Those will be in gardens, honored." (70:34-35)

7. Spending in God's Way

Spending in God's way holds a high position among praiseworthy deeds. Spending is not only praiseworthy in material and financial matters; rather, the most important spending in God's way is spending knowledge and wisdom and the rulings and teachings of religion. The Qur'an says:

"Who spend [in the cause of Allah] during ease and hardship... Those – their reward is forgiveness from their Lord and gardens beneath which rivers flow, wherein they will abide eternally; and excellent is the reward of the [righteous] workers." (3:134)

8. Martyrdom in God's Way

One who gives up their life—which is their most precious possession—in God's way has a very high station with God. God has explicitly stated that He places the martyr near Himself and provides for them. In Paradise, no reward is as valuable as the station of "nearness" or "proximity." The Qur'an says:

"And never think of those who have been killed in the cause of Allah as dead. Rather, they are alive with their Lord, receiving provision." (3:169)

